

Thesis Chapter Guide

*Land Records Modernisation in India:
Reading Plans, Argumentative Spines, and Writing Strategies for Chapters 2–7*

A consolidated working document, edited from an extended consultation on doctoral writing.

PhD in Development Studies

Tata Institute of Social Sciences, Mumbai

*Thesis: Political economy of DILRMP (Digital India Land Records Modernisation Programme),
with village and parcel-level fieldwork in Odisha.*

A note before you begin

This document consolidates an extended consultation on writing six chapters of a doctoral thesis. It is meant to be a working reference: you should be able to open it to any chapter and find, in one place, the argumentative spine for that chapter, the layered reading list, section-by-section writing guidance, and where relevant a deep dive into the primary government documents that anchor the argument empirically.

Six chapters are covered. **Chapter 2** is the historical and conceptual scaffold — a global and Indian history of land records, read through three theoretical traditions in conversation. **Chapter 3** moves into the political economy of contemporary land records modernisation in India, with particular attention to DILRMP, the post-1991 turn, and the welfare-electoral nexus that DBT has produced. **Chapter 4** grounds all of this in Odisha specifically, treating the state's tenurial heterogeneity as a palimpsest. **Chapters 5 and 6** are the empirical heart of the thesis: Chapter 5 at the village and household level, Chapter 6 at the parcel level, with the forensic comparison of digital, paper, and ground evidence that gives the thesis its methodological signature. **Chapter 7** is the conclusion.

References are tagged throughout with one to three stars. **Three stars** mark essential readings — texts that should be read fully or near-fully and that anchor the chapter's argument. **Two stars** mark important readings to engage selectively: introduction, key chapter, conclusion. **One star** marks texts useful for citation coverage, where abstract-level reading is sufficient. A doctoral chapter cannot meaningfully engage with eighty texts at full depth, and the layered-reading discipline is what makes any large bibliography manageable. The approximate proportions you are aiming for: twelve to fifteen texts at Layer 1, twenty-five to thirty at Layer 2, thirty to forty at Layer 3.

The document has been edited for readability. Repetition has been trimmed, transitions tightened, and the spoken register of the original consultation smoothed into something closer to a finished reference. No analytical content has been removed, and the references themselves are preserved exactly. Where a compact briefing block was prepared (for Chapter 2), it is retained at the end of that chapter for use in future sessions.

Chapter 2 — History and Evolution of Land Records: Global and Indian Contexts

The opening question

"I am writing my PhD thesis in Development Studies. I am currently trying to write my Chapter 2. How to start, and what are the best papers I should refer to? Treat this as extremely important. (1) Papers I must refer to formulate the chapter. (2) How to assemble all the concepts and researches to write the chapter. (3) A plan of action to finish."

What this chapter has to do

Chapter 2 carries unusual weight. It is the historical-conceptual scaffold on which everything else stands: the political economy chapter, the Odisha chapter, and the two empirical chapters that follow all rely on this one having done its work properly. If the scaffold is weak, the upper floors collapse.

The chapter's section structure is fixed: §2.1 on land records and their functions; §2.2 on the global evolution of land records and titling systems, broken into pre-colonial, colonial, post-colonial, and contemporary or neoliberal phases; §2.3 on the history of land records in India, again across pre-colonial, colonial settlements, and post-independence; §2.4 on the legal and institutional infrastructure for land records in India; and §2.5 on the genesis of DILRMP itself.

Within this structure, the analytical work is done by holding three traditions in conversation across four historical regimes. The three traditions are: state legibility (Scott, Cohn, Foucault), which answers *how* the state knows land; capitalist agrarian transition (Marx, Byres, Bernstein, Harvey, Levien), which answers *for whom* land is made knowable; and institutional economics (Smith, Locke, Coase, North, Demsetz, de Soto, Deininger, Acemoglu), which asks *whether* secure title is sufficient for development. The four regimes form a palimpsest: pre-colonial tributary records as fiscal-extraction instruments; colonial-capitalist records as the failed installation of capitalist property relations; post-independence redistributive records as unfinished land reform; and the contemporary neoliberal-titling regime as accumulation by dispossession through digital legibility.

The thesis sentence

The chapter's argumentative spine, which every section should serve and the conclusion of the chapter should restate, is the following:

DILRMP cannot be understood through one lens alone. It is simultaneously a state-legibility project, a capitalist-transition project, and an institutional-economics project — and the friction between these three logics produces the village-level contradictions documented in Chapter 5.

Several supporting claims follow from this. Indian land records are not a single inheritance but a palimpsest, and DILRMP attempts to flatten this palimpsest without acknowledging it. The Mughal *zabt-dahsala* system was fiscal in nature, not a property-rights system as later economists have read it: colonial settlements introduced juridical "property" as a new category, alien to the tributary

regime that preceded them. Pre-1991 Indian land records, accordingly, can be read as the administrative face of what Lerche has called the bypassed agrarian transition. DILRMP, on this account, is contemporary primitive accumulation operating through digital legibility rather than physical enclosure. And one more procedural point worth foregrounding for the reader: India continues to follow a presumptive (deeds-based) titling system, not a conclusive (Torrens-based) one. DILRMP's titling ambition is therefore radical, not merely administrative.

The thirty essential readings, organised

Theoretical and conceptual core

- 1. Marx, *Capital* Vol. I, Part VIII (Ch. 26–33) on primitive accumulation
- 2. Harvey (2003), *The New Imperialism*, Ch. 4 on accumulation by dispossession
- 3. Polanyi (1944), *The Great Transformation*, Ch. 6 on land as fictitious commodity
- 4. Scott (1998), *Seeing Like a State*, Ch. 1–2 on legibility and cadastral maps
- 5. Adam Smith, *Wealth of Nations*, Book III Ch. 1–4 on feudal land tenure
- 6. Locke, *Second Treatise*, Ch. 5 on property
- 7. Coase (1960), "The Problem of Social Cost"
- 8. North (1990), *Institutions, Institutional Change and Economic Performance*
- 9. Demsetz (1967), "Toward a Theory of Property Rights"
- 10. de Soto (2000), *The Mystery of Capital*
- 11. Payne, Durand-Lasserve and Rakodi (2009), "Limits of Land Titling"
- 12. Ostrom (1990), *Governing the Commons*

India — colonial core

- 13. Habib, *The Agrarian System of Mughal India 1556–1707* (revenue chapters)
- 14. Guha (1963), *A Rule of Property for Bengal*
- 15. Cohn (1996), *Colonialism and Its Forms of Knowledge*
- 16. Bhattacharya (2018), *The Great Agrarian Conquest*
- 17. Banaji (1977), "Capitalist Domination and the Small Peasantry," *EPW*
- 18. Banerjee and Iyer (2005), "History, Institutions, and Economic Performance," *AER*

India — post-independence

- 19. Appu (1996), *Land Reforms in India*
- 20. Patnaik (ed., 1990), *Agrarian Relations and Accumulation: The Mode of Production Debate*
- 21. Bhaduri (1973), "A Study in Agricultural Backwardness Under Semi-Feudalism," *Economic Journal*
- 22. Byres (1996), *Capitalism from Above and Capitalism from Below*
- 23. Bernstein (2010), *Class Dynamics of Agrarian Change*
- 24. Lerche (2013), "The Agrarian Question in Neoliberal India," *JAC*

- 25. Bina Agarwal (1994), *A Field of One's Own*
- 26. Wahi et al. (2018), CPR Land Rights Initiative report on Scheduled Areas

India — DILRMP and contemporary

- 27. Levien (2018), *Dispossession without Development*
- 28. Benjamin et al. (2007), CASUMM paper on Bhoomi
- 29. Pratyush (2023), "Illegibly Legible," JAC
- 30. NCAER/NIPFP/IGIDR DILRMP evaluation reports (2020); CPR (2022) on land rights and the digital revolution

Three versions of the chapter, in conversation

Across the consultation, three locked versions of the chapter framework were developed. They are not alternatives but layers: each applies a distinct analytical tradition to the same historical material, and the final chapter is written by holding all three in conversation. Treating them as substitutes weakens the argument; treating them as complementary is what gives the chapter its distinctive analytical power.

Version 1 — state legibility

The lens here is land records as instruments of state power. It answers the question: how does the state make land knowable? The argument, in compressed form: from the Mughal *zabt-dahsala* through Cornwallis's cadastres through DILRMP's digital integration, the Indian state has progressively produced legibility over land, and each phase of legibility produces specific exclusions and specific possibilities of governance. Scott, Cohn, Foucault are the anchors; Bhattacharya's *The Great Agrarian Conquest* is the India-specific extension.

Version 2 — capitalist agrarian transition

Here the lens is land records as instruments of capitalist class formation. The question becomes: why does the state make land knowable — for whose accumulation? The argument: the Permanent Settlement attempted, and largely failed, to install capitalist property relations in India; the post-independence reforms partially redistributed but did not complete the agrarian transition; and DILRMP is the contemporary attempt to make Indian agrarian land legible to capital, in a state that has bypassed the classical agrarian transition. Marx, Byres, Bernstein, Harvey, Levien anchor this version; Lerche provides the framing concept (the bypassed transition).

Version 3 — classical and institutional economics

The third lens reads land records as institutions that lower transaction costs and shape incentives, but also entrench distributive conflicts. It asks: whether well-defined property rights are necessary, sufficient, both, or neither for development. The dominant institutional-economics view treats secure title as a precondition for growth and welfare; the agrarian political-economy view treats secure title as an instrument of class differentiation; the legibility view treats it as a state project of population management. All three are true at once. DILRMP embodies all three logics simultaneously, in tension — and that is the argument the chapter exists to make.

A unifying paragraph for the colonial section

A useful model for how all three traditions can converge on the same historical moment is the Permanent Settlement. The paragraph would read:

Three different scholarly traditions converge on a single observation about Permanent Settlement: that it created landlordism without creating productive capitalist agriculture. The agrarian-political-economy tradition (Habib, Guha, Banaji) reads this as the failure of capitalist transition under colonial conditions. The state-legibility tradition (Cohn, Bhattacharya) reads it as a colonial knowledge-construction project that produced "the landlord" as a juridical subject. The new institutional economics tradition (Banerjee and Iyer 2005) reads it as a property-rights configuration whose long-run consequences for agricultural investment can be empirically measured. These are three different questions about the same historical moment, and they yield three complementary, not competing, accounts.

Section-by-section argumentative moves

§2.1 — Functions of land records

Open with a four-function typology: fiscal, juridical, economic, and governmental. The fiscal and governmental functions come from Scott and Foucault; the juridical and economic functions come from Marx and Smith. Indian land records do all four simultaneously. Polanyi's notion of land as a "fictitious commodity" is the synthesising idea: land is not naturally a commodity, but is *made* into one administratively, fiscally, and ideologically. Records do this work.

§2.2 — Global evolution

A crisp historical arc is the right approach here: medieval and feudal records (Domesday, *terriers*); early modern cadastres (Napoleonic); colonial cadastres (European empires); post-WWII titling waves in Africa, Latin America, and Asia; the neoliberal titling consensus (post-1990s, World Bank, de Soto). Smith and Locke do the philosophical work for the early modern transition; Coase, North, Demsetz, de Soto for the contemporary one.

§2.3 — India in three layers

The Indian section is the long one and the one that requires most discipline. In §2.3.1, treat Mughal records as fiscal-tributary infrastructure: Habib is the foundational source. In §2.3.2, treat colonial records as the failed capitalist-transition project: Guha and Banaji provide the political-economic frame, Banerjee and Iyer the empirical bridge, Cohn and Bhattacharya the legibility frame. Banerjee and Iyer is central here precisely because it connects V3 and V2 — both Permanent Settlement and Ryotwari were "bad" in different ways for different reasons, and Banerjee and Iyer give you the long-run empirical fingerprint. In §2.3.3, treat post-independence records as redistributive-reform-as-paper: Appu, Patnaik, Bhaduri, Lerche, Bardhan. The mode of production debate adjudicates whether Indian agriculture is capitalist or semi-feudal; the institutional-economics literature asks whether secure individual property rights would unlock growth. Both speak to the same empirical reality, and your chapter should make that clear.

§2.4 — Legal and institutional infrastructure

This is the section where explicit transaction-cost analysis pays off. India's deeds-based system has high transaction costs, deters investment, and encourages litigation. The Carnegie India argument gets sharpened by Coase and North. But Bardhan and Ostrom remind us that lowering transaction costs is not the only thing that matters. Distributive politics, commons, customary rights, and gendered exclusions cannot be solved by titling alone. The section should hold both these positions together.

§2.5 — Genesis of DILRMP

DILRMP appears at the convergence of four currents: the unresolved post-reform obsolescence of records (the bypassed agrarian transition); the neoliberal turn in Indian state policy after 1991; the Washington Consensus and its NIE intellectual basis; and the Digital India / JAM trinity infrastructural turn. The closing paragraph of the chapter should suggest that Chapter 3 will pursue this convergence as a political-economy problem, while Chapters 4 to 6 will examine its material outcomes at village and parcel level in Odisha.

A six-week reading schedule

With the structure clear, the practical question is how to read all of this in time. A workable six-week schedule looks like this:

- **Week 1** — the theoretical core: Marx, Harvey, Scott, Smith, Coase, North, de Soto
- **Week 2** — Byres, Bernstein, Lerche; Habib and Guha
- **Week 3** — Cohn, Bhattacharya, Banaji, Banerjee and Iyer, the mode of production debate
- **Week 4** — Appu, Wahi, Levien; draft §2.4 and §2.5
- **Week 5** — DILRMP-specific (NCAER/NIPFP/IGIDR, Benjamin, Pratyush); restructure
- **Week 6** — Odisha-specific texts, polish, bibliography, supervisor submission

The corrected reading sequence after Scott

A reader who has finished Scott's *Seeing Like a State* should not jump straight to de Soto; the conceptual ground in between needs to be laid in a particular order. The right sequence is as follows.

- 1. **Bernard S. Cohn (1996)**, *Colonialism and Its Forms of Knowledge* — Introduction and "The Census, Social Structure and Objectification in South Asia"
- 2. **Matthew Edney (1997)**, *Mapping an Empire* — Introduction and Ch. 1
- 3. **Nicholas Dirks (2001)**, *Castes of Mind* — Introduction and Ch. 2
- 4. **Ranajit Guha (1963)**, *A Rule of Property for Bengal* — read fully
- 5. **Irfan Habib**, *The Agrarian System of Mughal India* — revenue chapters
- 6. **Neeladri Bhattacharya (2018)**, *The Great Agrarian Conquest* — read fully
- 7. **Hernando de Soto (2000)**, *The Mystery of Capital* — Ch. 1, 2, 5
- 8. **Payne, Durand-Lasserve and Rakodi (2009)** — the empirical critique of de Soto
- 9. **Amit Bhaduri (1973)** — semi-feudalism
- 10. **T. J. Byres (1986)**, *Social Scientist* — agrarian transition paths
- 11. **Jens Lerche (2013)** — neoliberal India and the bypassed transition
- 12. **Douglass North (1994)**, Nobel Lecture — twelve pages, well worth reading
- 13. **Banerjee and Iyer (2005)** — colonial tenure legacy
- 14. **Pranab Bardhan (2005)** — internal NIE critique
- 15. **Benjamin (2007)**, **Pratyush (2023)**, **NCAER (2020)** — DILRMP-specific
- 16. **Marx Part VIII and Harvey Ch. 4** — read last, as synthesis

An honest layered-reading hierarchy

The thirty essentials, plus the wider literature you should know but cannot read fully, distribute across three layers in roughly this way.

Layer 1 — read fully (about fifteen texts)

Scott, Cohn, Guha, Bhattacharya, Habib, Marx Part VIII, Byres 1986, Lerche 2013, Bhaduri 1973, de Soto, Banerjee and Iyer 2005, Benjamin et al. 2007 on Bhoomi, Pratyush 2023, Levien 2018, Appu 1996.

Layer 2 — read selectively (about twenty-five texts)

Edney, Dirks, Stokes, Washbrook, Banaji 1977, Bernstein 2010, Harvey 2003, Polanyi, Smith Book III, North's Nobel Lecture, Coase 1960, Demsetz 1967, Bardhan 2005, Ostrom 1990, Deininger 2003, Payne et al. 2009, Agarwal 1994, Patnaik (ed.) 1990, Gupta 2012, NCAER 2020, CPR 2022, Carnegie India 2019, Wahi et al. 2018, Kohli 2006, Foucault 1991.

Layer 3 — citation coverage (about thirty texts)

Williamson on Washington Consensus, Acemoglu and Robinson, Iversen, Palmer-Jones and Sen, Borrás and Franco, Tania Li, Stein, Frykenberg, Hatekar, Bose, Federici, Chang, Bardhan 1989, Locke, Ricardo, Bernstein 2006, Levien 2015, Shah and Lerche, Drèze, Khera, Khalid and Somanchi, Khera (ed.), Burman at NIPFP, Saxena, Wahi 2013, Thara, the IGIDR and NIPFP state reports, Das on illegibility, Lund, the Odisha-specific texts, and others as the bibliography demands.

A verified Foucault citation

The Foucault citation that the chapter rests on, in its preferred form:

Foucault, Michel (1991). "Governmentality." In Graham Burchell, Colin Gordon and Peter Miller (eds.), *The Foucault Effect: Studies in Governmentality with Two Lectures by and an Interview with Michel Foucault*, pp. 87–104. Chicago: University of Chicago Press. (Simultaneously published London: Harvester Wheatsheaf.) Chapter 4 only. A PDF is available at Monoskop.

Originally delivered as a lecture on 1 February 1978 at the Collège de France. An alternative citation, if a Foucault specialist on the committee prefers the full lecture course, is: Foucault, Michel (2007), *Security, Territory, Population: Lectures at the Collège de France 1977–78*, edited by Senellart and translated by Burchell, Basingstoke: Palgrave Macmillan.

Compact briefing block for Chapter 2

A briefing block was prepared during the consultation, intended to be pasted at the start of a fresh session so that all the conceptual scaffolding could be carried forward without exhausting tokens. It is retained here, with light editing, for the same purpose.

Who I am

I am a PhD student in Development Studies at TISS Mumbai. My thesis is on land records modernisation in India, focusing on DILRMP, with village and parcel-level fieldwork in Odisha. I am writing Chapter 2: History and Evolution of Land Records — Global and Indian Contexts.

Chapter 2 sections (locked)

- 2.1 Land records and their functions
- 2.2 Evolution of land records and titling systems globally (2.2.1 pre-colonial; 2.2.2 colonial; 2.2.3 post-colonial; 2.2.4 contemporary/neoliberal)
- 2.3 History of land records in India (2.3.1 pre-colonial; 2.3.2 colonial settlements; 2.3.3 post-independence)
- 2.4 Legal and institutional infrastructure for land records in India
- 2.5 Genesis of DILRMP

Argumentative spine (locked)

Three analytical traditions in conversation:

- **State legibility** (Scott, Cohn, Foucault) — how the state knows land
- **Capitalist agrarian transition** (Marx, Byres, Bernstein, Harvey, Levien) — for whom land is made knowable
- **Institutional economics** (Smith, Locke, Coase, North, Demsetz, de Soto, Deininger, Acemoglu) — whether secure title is sufficient

Four regimes (palimpsest): pre-colonial tributary; colonial-capitalist-failed; post-independence redistributive-failed; neoliberal-titling.

Core thesis sentence

DILRMP cannot be understood through one lens alone. It is simultaneously a state-legibility project, a capitalist-transition project, and an institutional-economics project — and the friction between these three logics produces the village-level contradictions documented in Chapter 5.

Style and supervision context

- TISS expects engagement with both the South Asianist agrarian-studies tradition and mainstream development economics
- The supervisor will expect explicit engagement with the mode-of-production debate
- Bibliography style: Harvard or Chicago (verify with supervisor)
- Paraphrase rather than quote
- Write the chapter introduction last

Chapter 3 — Political Economy of Land Records Modernisation in India

The question that opens this chapter

"Wonderful. I want to probe further and seek references for Chapter 3. Same effort and judiciousness. Chapter 3 sections are: §3.1 Land governance under neoliberalism; §3.2 Land records modernisation and DILRMP; §3.3 State welfare — land records and DBT; §3.4 Critical reflections on the technocratic reforms."

What is at stake

If Chapter 2 was about history and concepts — the "what" and "how" of land records — Chapter 3 is where the political-economy argument finally gets made. It answers the "why now, why this way, and in whose interest." The historical scaffolding from Chapter 2 must do active work in this chapter; without it, Chapter 3 risks reading as commentary on contemporary policy rather than as the analytical core of a doctoral thesis.

The argumentative spine

The central claim of Chapter 3, which every section serves, runs as follows:

DILRMP is not a technocratic land-administration reform; it is the administrative apparatus through which India's post-1991 neoliberal state seeks simultaneously to (a) commodify land for accumulation, (b) target welfare through digital legibility, and (c) construct a market-compatible juridical subject — and the contradictions between these three projects are what produce the implementation failures, exclusions, and contestations documented in subsequent chapters.

Each of the four sections contributes one move toward this argument. §3.1 establishes the macro-political-economy frame, treating neoliberalism as the conditioning context. §3.2 dissects the policy object itself: DILRMP's design, integration, and titling ambition. §3.3 examines the welfare-targeting function, asking how land records have become the gateway to Direct Benefit Transfer. §3.4 develops the critical synthesis, showing why technocratic reform cannot solve what is fundamentally political.

§3.1 — Land governance under neoliberalism

The Indian liberalisation literature

The macro frame for this chapter is the post-1991 neoliberal turn in Indian political economy. Atul Kohli's distinction between the pro-business turn of the 1980s and the pro-market turn of the 1990s is the most useful entry point. The agrarian dimension of this transition — the deflationary squeeze on agriculture, the rise of agrarian distress, the political-economic conditions of farmer suicide — is treated most clearly by Utsa Patnaik. The transformation of land itself into a commodity, particularly through the SEZ regime and post-2005 dispossession, is the subject of Michael Levien's work, which is central here.

Indian political economy after 1991

- ★★★ Atul Kohli (2006), "Politics of Economic Growth in India, 1980–2005," *EPW* 41(13–14). Distinguishes the "pro-business" turn of the 1980s from the "pro-market" turn of the 1990s.
- ★★★ Atul Kohli (2012), *Poverty Amid Plenty in the New India*, Cambridge University Press.
- ★★★ Stuart Corbridge and John Harriss (2000), *Reinventing India: Liberalization, Hindu Nationalism and Popular Democracy*, Polity.
- ★★ Corbridge, Harriss and Craig Jeffrey (2013), *India Today: Economy, Politics and Society*, Polity.
- ★★ Pranab Bardhan (1984, revised editions), *The Political Economy of Development in India*, Oxford University Press — the classic three-class coalition argument.
- ★★ Achin Vanaik (2017), *The Rise of Hindu Authoritarianism*, Verso.
- ★★ Christophe Jaffrelot (2018), *India's Democracy at 70*, Routledge.

Agriculture under liberalisation

- ★★★ Utsa Patnaik (2007), *The Republic of Hunger and Other Essays*, Three Essays Collective. The argument that neoliberal reforms produced a deflationary squeeze on agriculture is the analytical anchor for §3.1.1.
- ★★★ Utsa Patnaik (2003), "Global Capitalism, Deflation and Agrarian Crisis in Developing Countries," *JAC* 3(1–2): 33–66.
- ★★★ Jayati Ghosh (2010), "The Political Economy of Hunger in 21st Century India," *EPW* 45(44–45).
- ★★ C. P. Chandrasekhar and Jayati Ghosh (2002), *The Market That Failed*, LeftWord.
- ★★ Surinder S. Jodhka (2012), *Village Society*, Orient BlackSwan.
- ★★ R. Ramakumar (2017) and Foundation for Agrarian Studies authors on agrarian distress under neoliberalism. *Review of Agrarian Studies*, multiple issues.
- ★★ A. Vaidyanathan (2010), *Agricultural Growth in India*, OUP.
- ★★ P. Sainath, *Everybody Loves a Good Drought* (1996) and subsequent journalism.

Land as commodity

- ★★★ **Michael Levien (2018)**, *Dispossession without Development*, Oxford University Press. Central. The shift from "developmentalist" land regime to "broker" land regime is the single most useful conceptual frame in this section.
- ★★★ **Michael Levien (2013)**, "Regimes of Dispossession: From Steel Towns to Special Economic Zones," *Development and Change* 44(2).
- ★★★ **Michael Levien (2015)**, "From Primitive Accumulation to Regimes of Dispossession," *EPW* 50(22).
- ★★ **Michael Levien (2011)**, "Rationalising Dispossession: The Land Acquisition and Resettlement Bills," *EPW* 46(11).
- ★★ **A. R. Vasavi (2012)**, *Shadow Space: Suicides and the Predicament of Rural India*, Three Essays Collective.

The Land Acquisition Act trajectory

- ★★★ LARR Act, 2013 — primary source; read key sections directly
- ★★ **Namita Wahi (2013)**, "Land Acquisition, Development and the Constitution," *Seminar* 642
- ★★ **Sanjoy Chakravorty (2013)**, *The Price of Land*, OUP
- ★★ **Walter Fernandes (2007)**, "Singur and the Displacement Scenario," *EPW* 42(3)
- ★★ **A. Banerjee, P. Bardhan, M. Ghatak et al. (2007)**, "Beyond Nandigram: Industrialisation in West Bengal," *EPW* 42(17)
- ★★ **Partha Chatterjee (2008)**, "Democracy and Economic Transformation in India," *EPW* 43(16)

The role of international institutions

The argument that DILRMP is intelligible only against the backdrop of World Bank land policy is one your committee will expect you to make explicitly. Deininger's *Land Policies for Growth and Poverty Reduction* is the doctrinal document; the LGAF reports for Indian states (Odisha's 2017 report is particularly relevant for you) are the operational documents. Beyond the Bank, the Washington Consensus framing in Williamson and the broader IMF conditionality story complete the picture.

World Bank land policy doctrine

- ★★★ **Klaus Deininger (2003)**, *Land Policies for Growth and Poverty Reduction*, World Bank. The doctrinal document.
- ★★★ **Klaus Deininger and Hans Binswanger (1999)**, "The Evolution of the World Bank's Land Policy," *World Bank Research Observer* 14(2).
- ★★ **World Bank (2007)**, *India: Land Policies for Growth and Poverty Reduction*.
- ★★ **World Bank Land Governance Assessment Framework (LGAF) reports for Indian states**: Odisha (2017) is in your bibliography.
- ★★ **Klaus Deininger, Aparajita Goyal and Hari Nagarajan (2013)**, "Women's Inheritance Rights and Intergenerational Transmission of Resources in India," *Journal of Human Resources* 48(1).

- ★★ Deininger, Jin, Nagarajan and Xia (2014), "Moving Off the Farm," *World Development* 59.

The Washington Consensus and India

- ★★★ John Williamson (1990), "What Washington Means by Policy Reform." Read the property-rights item specifically.
- ★★★ Joseph Stiglitz (2002), *Globalization and Its Discontents*, Norton.
- ★★ Dani Rodrik (2006), "Goodbye Washington Consensus, Hello Washington Confusion?" *JEL* 44(4).
- ★★ Ha-Joon Chang (2002), *Kicking Away the Ladder*, Anthem.
- ★★★ Vijay Joshi and I. M. D. Little (1996), *India's Economic Reforms 1991–2001*, OUP.
- ★★ Rahul Mukherji (2013), "Ideas, Interests, and the Tipping Point," *RIPE* 20(2).
- ★★ Rob Jenkins (1999), *Democratic Politics and Economic Reform in India*, Cambridge UP — the "reform by stealth" thesis.
- ★★ Aseema Sinha (2016), *Globalizing India*, Cambridge UP.
- ★★ Government of India (1993), Memorandum to the IMF and Letters of Intent — primary sources.

§3.2 — Land records modernisation and DILRMP

The design of DILRMP

This section requires direct engagement with the primary documents of the programme itself. The DoLR guidelines — CLR 1988–89, SRA&ULR 1987–88, NLRMP 2008, and the DILRMP Central Sector Scheme guidelines from 2016 onwards — together constitute the official architecture. The 2022 *Best Practices in DILRMP* booklet is particularly useful as a primary source against which empirical evidence can later be read. Alongside the primary documents, the critical scholarly literature on DILRMP is small but pointed: Solomon Benjamin and his collaborators on Bhoomi, Pritam Pratyush on the illegibility produced by digitisation, N. C. Saxena on the limits of computerisation, Anirudh Burman at NIPFP on the integration problem.

Primary source documents

- ★★★ Department of Land Resources (DoLR), Ministry of Rural Development:
 - Computerisation of Land Records (CLR) Scheme Guidelines, 1988–89
 - SRA&ULR Guidelines, 1987–88
 - NLRMP Guidelines, 2008 — the foundational document
 - DILRMP Central Sector Scheme Guidelines, 2016
 - DILRMP Extension Guidelines 2021–22 to 2025–26
 - DILRMP Operational Manual
- ★★★ DILRMP MIS Dashboard (dilrmp.gov.in) — component-wise progress data
- ★★ DoLR (2022), *Best Practices in DILRMP* booklet — crucial primary source

Critical scholarly literature

- ★★★ Solomon Benjamin et al. (2007), "Bhoomi: 'E-Governance', Or, an Anti-Politics Machine?" CASUMM Working Paper.
- ★★★ Pritam Pratyush (2023), "Illegibly Legible," JAC 23(4).
- ★★★ N. C. Saxena (2004), *Updating Land Records: Is Computerisation Sufficient?* IDS-LSE Working Paper.
- ★★★ Anirudh Burman (2019), "Improving Land Records in India," NIPFP Working Paper.
- ★★ CPR (2022), *Land Rights and the Digital Revolution in India*.
- ★★ Silvia Masiero (2016), "Digital Governance and the Reconstruction of the Indian Anti-Poverty System."

State-level evaluation reports

- ★★★ NCAER (2020), *Synthesis Report: Pilot Impact Assessment Study of DILRMP*.
- ★★★ NCAER (2020), Himachal Pradesh DILRMP Impact Assessment, Perna Prabhakar et al.
- ★★★ NIPFP (2020), Rajasthan DILRMP Impact Assessment, Anirudh Burman et al.
- ★★★ IGIDR (2020), Maharashtra DILRMP Impact Assessment, Diya Uday et al.

Integration of RoR, cadastral maps, and registration

India's three-system architecture — Record of Rights, cadastral maps, and registration of deeds — was never designed for integration, and DILRMP's attempt to bring the three together is what makes the programme technically distinctive. Anirudh Burman's NIPFP work is the clearest analytical treatment of the integration problem; PRS Legislative Research's recent overview is a useful companion. The historical baseline matters here: the 2009 Committee on State Agrarian Relations observed that the average age of village and cadastral maps in most Indian states is more than fifty years, prepared during the British regime. This is a crucial citation for showing why integration is hard.

- ★★★ Anirudh Burman (2019, 2020, 2021), NIPFP working papers
- ★★★ PRS Legislative Research (2024), *Land Records and Titles in India*
- ★★ N. C. Saxena (2019), "Updating Land Records," in *Land Reforms in India Vol. 15*, Sage
- ★★ Ministry of Panchayati Raj (2020 onwards), SVAMITVA Scheme documentation
- ★★ K. Thara (2022), *SVAMITVA: A Socio-Legal Analysis*, CSEP Working Paper 26
- ★★ Registration Act 1908, Indian Stamp Act 1899, Transfer of Property Act 1882 — primary statutory framework

The shift toward conclusive titling

The policy shift from a deeds-based (presumptive) titling system to a Torrens-style conclusive one is the most ambitious dimension of DILRMP and the one most worth dwelling on. NITI Aayog's *Model Bill on Conclusive Land Titling, 2020* is the primary document and must be read directly. The Carnegie India paper on title insurance offers a useful alternative framing that the Rajan Committee (2009) had also gestured at. The comparative literature on Torrens systems and the political-economic critique of titling (de Soto vs Payne and colleagues, Tania Li, Brenna Bhandar) together do the analytical work.

The Model Bill and policy shift

- ★★★ **NITI Aayog (2020)**, *Model Bill on Conclusive Land Titling, 2020* — primary, read directly
- ★★★ Land Titling Bill, 2011 (Model) — primary
- ★★★ **Carnegie India (2019)**, *Making Land Titles in India Marketable: Using Title Insurance as a Viable Alternative to Conclusive Titling*
- ★★ **Committee on Financial Sector Reforms (Rajan Committee, 2009)**, *A Hundred Small Steps*

Torrens and the comparative frame

- ★★ **Benito Arruñada (2003)**, "Property Titling and Conveyancing"
- ★★ **Pamela O'Connor (2003)**, "Registration of Title in England and Australia"
- ★★ **Alain Pottage (1995)**, "The Originality of Registration," *OJLS* 15(3)

The political economy of titling

- ★★★ **Hernando de Soto (2000)**, *The Mystery of Capital* — the intellectual basis
- ★★★ **Payne, Durand-Lasserve and Rakodi (2009)** — the empirical rebuttal
- ★★ **Tania Murray Li (2014)**, *Land's End*
- ★★ **Sara Berry (2009)**, "Property, Authority and Citizenship," *D&C* 40(1)
- ★★ **Christian Lund and Catherine Boone (2013)**, "Land Politics in Africa," *Africa* 83(1)
- ★★ **Brenna Bhandar (2018)**, *Colonial Lives of Property*, Duke UP

§3.3 — State welfare and DBT

This section is the most contemporary, and analytically the most pointed. The argument is that DBT-based cash transfers — PM-Kisan, KALIA, Subhadra, and the proliferation of women-specific schemes — have come to substitute for structural reform of agrarian distress, employment, and inequality, and that the land records infrastructure is what makes this substitution operationally possible. The literature on this has been building rapidly. Yamini Aiyar, Neelanjan Sircar, and Louise Tillin are the most important contemporary voices.

Foundational scholarship on "new welfarism" and techno-patrimonialism

Yamini Aiyar — the central voice

- ★★★ Yamini Aiyar (2019), "Modi Consolidates Power: Leveraging Welfare Politics," *Journal of Democracy* 30(4): 78–88. The foundational essay.
- ★★★ Yamini Aiyar (2023), "Citizen vs Labharthi? Interrogating the Contours of India's Emergent Welfare State," *India Forum*, 13 December 2023.
- ★★★ Yamini Aiyar and Neelanjan Sircar (2024) on techno-patrimonial welfare; CASI Election Conversations 2024 series.
- ★★★ Yamini Aiyar and Rohan Venkat (2024), "With Jobless Growth, Welfare Has Become a 'Compensation,' Not a Public Right," *Scroll.in*, April 2024.

Neelanjan Sircar — the politics of vishwas

- ★★★ Neelanjan Sircar (2020), "The Politics of Vishwas: Political Mobilization in the 2019 National Election," *Contemporary South Asia* 28(2)
- ★★★ Neelanjan Sircar (2021), "Modi's Centralisation of Welfare Delivery," *The Print*

Louise Tillin — the *longue-durée* welfare state

- ★★★ Louise Tillin (2025), *Making India Work: The Development of Welfare in a Multi-Level Democracy*, Cambridge UP
- ★★★ Rajeshwari Deshpande, Louise Tillin and K. K. Kailash (2019), "The BJP's Welfare Schemes: Did They Make a Difference in the 2019 Elections?" *Studies in Indian Politics* 7(2)

Other voices

- ★★ Hilal Ahmed (2022), "BJP's Electoral Victories Are a Result of a New Kind of Welfarism," *Indian Express*, 14 March 2022 — the "charitable state" framing
- ★★★ Arvind Subramanian, Arvind Virmani, Naveen Joseph Thomas (2022), "The New Welfarism of Modi's Government," *Business Standard*
- ★★ Arvind Subramanian and Josh Felman (2023), "India's Stalled Rise," *Foreign Affairs*
- ★★ Devesh Kapur, multiple essays on the "virus of cash transfers"

Cash transfers, women voters, and competitive welfarism

A specific subset of the welfare literature focuses on cash transfers to women as the most consequential electoral instrument of the past decade. The state schemes — Madhya Pradesh's Ladli Behna, Maharashtra's Ladki Bahin, Karnataka's Gruha Lakshmi, Telangana's Mahalakshmi, West Bengal's Lakshmir Bhandar, Tamil Nadu's Magalir Urimai Thogai, Bihar's 2025 transfer, and Odisha's Subhadra Yojana (directly relevant to your fieldwork) — together constitute the empirical material. Mukulika Banerjee's recent commentary and the European Center for Populism Studies analysis of the 2025 Bihar elections are useful contemporary anchors.

- ★★★ Pragya Tiwari and Mukulika Banerjee, "Cash Transfer for Women: The New Trend Shaping Indian Electoral Politics," The India Briefing podcast / South Asia@LSE blog, December 2024

- ★★★ **ECPS (2025)**, "Voting with Freebies: How Direct Welfare Benefits Reshape Electoral Behaviour in India" — 2025 Bihar elections analysis
- ★★ State-specific cash transfer schemes — primary sources: Ladli Behna (MP), Ladki Bahin (Maharashtra), Gruha Lakshmi (Karnataka), Mahalakshmi (Telangana), Lakshmir Bhandar (West Bengal), Magalir Urimai Thogai (Tamil Nadu), Subhadra Yojana (Odisha 2024), Bihar 2025 transfer

The clientelism literature

The deeper conceptual frame for the welfare-electoral nexus is provided by the clientelism literature. Pranab Bardhan and Dilip Mookherjee's recent *Quantitative Economics* paper is the most directly relevant: it shows that voters respond differently to welfare versus public-good programmes, and that this difference is systematically exploited by political parties. Mukulika Banerjee's *Why India Votes?* provides the anthropological counterpoint. The comparative literature (Stokes and colleagues, Thachil) gives international context.

- ★★★ **Pranab Bardhan, Sandip Mitra, Dilip Mookherjee, Abhirup Sarkar (2009)**, "Local Democracy and Clientelism," *EPW* 44(9)
- ★★★ **Bardhan, Mookherjee et al. (2024)**, "How Do Voters Respond to Welfare vis-à-vis Public Good Programs?" *Quantitative Economics*, July 2024
- ★★★ **Mukulika Banerjee (2014)**, *Why India Votes?* Routledge India
- ★★ **Susan Stokes, Thad Dunning et al. (2013)**, *Brokers, Voters, and Clientelism*, Cambridge UP
- ★★ **Tariq Thachil (2014)**, *Elite Parties, Poor Voters*, Cambridge UP

The substitution thesis

The argument that DBT has come to substitute for structural reform requires both a structural-economic case (the jobless-growth literature) and an empirical-distributive case (the welfare-exclusion literature). The Azim Premji University *State of Working India* reports, the PLFS data, and the Swaminathan Commission reports together establish that India has not produced the structural employment transformation that an actual response to agrarian distress would have required. PM-Kisan, KALIA, and the rest are what is offered in place of that response.

- ★★★ **Jens Lerche (2013)**, "Agrarian Question in Neoliberal India" — the structural context
- ★★★ *State of Working India* reports, Azim Premji University, annual editions 2018–2024
- ★★★ Periodic Labour Force Survey (PLFS) Reports, NSO/MoSPI
- ★★ **Mehrotra and Parida (2017, 2019)** on India's employment crisis
- ★★ Reports of the National Commission on Farmers (Swaminathan Commission, 2004–06) — primary
- ★★ NSSO 77th Round (2018–19), *Land and Livestock Holdings and Situation Assessment of Agricultural Households*

PM-Kisan and the land-records-welfare nexus

The specific link between land records and DBT, which the thesis has the unique vantage to make, runs through PM-Kisan. Eligibility for PM-Kisan is constructed entirely from land records; this means that every error, exclusion, and discrepancy in the records translates directly into welfare exclusion. The Operational Guidelines are the primary document; R. Ramakumar's *India Forum* assessment is the sharpest scholarly critique to date.

- ★★★ Government of India, *PM-Kisan Operational Guidelines* — primary
- ★★ R. Ramakumar (2020), "PM-KISAN: A Critical Assessment," *India Forum*
- ★★ Department of Agriculture and Farmers Welfare, *PM-KISAN Status Reports*

Aadhaar, biometric exclusion, and digital welfare

The Aadhaar-DBT system as a whole is what makes the land-records-welfare nexus work. The literature on its exclusions is by now substantial, with Drèze, Khera, and colleagues providing the methodological template; LibTech India providing the most detailed empirical fieldwork; and Muralidharan, Niehaus and Sukhtankar providing the pro-DBT empirical case that you must engage with critically.

- ★★★ Reetika Khera (ed., 2019), *Dissent on Aadhaar: Big Data Meets Big Brother*, Orient BlackSwan
- ★★★ Drèze, Khalid, Khera and Somanchi (2017), "Aadhaar and Food Security in Jharkhand: Pain without Gain?" *EPW* 52(50). The methodological template.
- ★★★ Ursula Rao and Vijayanka Nair (2019), "Aadhaar: Governing with Biometrics," *South Asia* 42(3)
- ★★ LibTech India — multiple reports
- ★★ Karthik Muralidharan, Paul Niehaus, Sandip Sukhtankar (2016), "Building State Capacity: Evidence from Biometric Smartcards in India," *AER* 106(10) — the pro-DBT empirical paper; engage critically

AgriStack and digital agriculture

AgriStack is the next chapter in this story. The IDEA Consultation Paper (2021) is the foundational primary document, the Digital Agriculture Mission Guidelines (2024) the operational one. ASHA's critical response and the working papers from CIS Bangalore, IT for Change, and the Internet Freedom Foundation provide the civil-society counter-discourse.

- ★★★ IDEA Consultation Paper, 2021, Ministry of Agriculture — primary
- ★★★ Ministry of Agriculture (2024), *Digital Agriculture Mission Guidelines*
- ★★ Alliance for Sustainable and Holistic Agriculture (ASHA) letter to Agriculture Ministry, 2021
- ★★ CIS Bangalore, IT for Change, Internet Freedom Foundation (IFF) reports on AgriStack

§3.4 — Critical reflections on technocratic reforms

The final section synthesises the argument and pushes it toward its political conclusion. The theoretical anchors here are the canonical critiques of technocracy in development: Ferguson's *The Anti-Politics Machine*, Tania Li's *The Will to Improve*, the broader literature on "rendering technical." For the digital-governance dimension specifically, Zuboff, Eubanks, and the data-justice literature provide contemporary framing. The India-specific critical voices — Akhil Gupta, Veena Das, IT for Change — do the indigenisation.

Theoretical anchors

- ★★★ **James Ferguson (1990)**, *The Anti-Politics Machine*, University of Minnesota Press. The argument that development projects systematically depoliticise inherently political questions is the single most important theoretical frame for §3.4.
- ★★★ **Tania Murray Li (2007)**, *The Will to Improve*, Duke UP. "Rendering technical."
- ★★ **David Mosse (2005)**, *Cultivating Development*, Pluto
- ★★ **Arturo Escobar (1995)**, *Encountering Development*, Princeton UP
- ★★★ **Langdon Winner (1980)**, "Do Artifacts Have Politics?" *Daedalus* 109(1). Foundational.
- ★★ **Sheila Jasanoff (ed., 2004)**, *States of Knowledge*, Routledge
- ★★ **Wendy Brown (2015)**, *Undoing the Demos*, Zone Books
- ★★★ **Shoshana Zuboff (2019)**, *The Age of Surveillance Capitalism*, PublicAffairs
- ★★ **Virginia Eubanks (2018)**, *Automating Inequality*, St. Martin's Press
- ★★ **Linnet Taylor (2017)**, "What is Data Justice?" *Big Data & Society* 4(2)

India-specific critical voices

- ★★★ **Akhil Gupta (1995)**, "Blurred Boundaries," *American Ethnologist* 22(2)
- ★★★ **Akhil Gupta (2012)**, *Red Tape*, Duke UP
- ★★ **Veena Das (2004)**, "The Signature of the State: The Paradox of Illegibility," in *Anthropology in the Margins of the State*
- ★★ **Anita Gurumurthy and Nandini Chami (IT for Change)** — multiple working papers

Political theory of welfare under neoliberalism

- ★★★ **Partha Chatterjee (2004)**, *The Politics of the Governed*, Columbia UP. The civil/political society distinction is the deepest theoretical frame for the labharthi argument.
- ★★ **Partha Chatterjee (2008)**, "Democracy and Economic Transformation in India," *EPW* 43(16)
- ★★ **Stuart Corbridge et al. (2005)**, *Seeing the State*, Cambridge UP

Government resources: a deep dive

A doctoral chapter on the political economy of an Indian government programme has to engage directly with the government's own paper trail. This is unusually rewarding for DILRMP because the documents are extensive, layered, and reveal more than their authors intended. What follows is an organised inventory of the most important clusters.

Cluster A — Department of Land Resources

The DoLR is the nodal agency for DILRMP and has produced the bulk of the official documentation. Beyond the scheme guidelines listed above, three documents are particularly worth treating as primary sources for the political-economy argument. The *Committee on State Agrarian Relations and the Unfinished Task of Land Reforms* (2009), chaired by N. C. Saxena, is the most important single document — it famously described corporate land acquisition as "the biggest land grab since Columbus" and was withdrawn after political backlash. The withdrawal is itself part of the story. The *Draft National Land Reforms Policy 2013*, released for public consultation but never enacted, is the second. The DoLR's annual reports from 2008 onwards complete the picture.

- CLR Guidelines 1988–89, SRA&ULR 1987–88, NLRMP 2008, DILRMP CSS 2016, DILRMP Extension 2021–26, Best Practices Booklet 2022
- DILRMP MIS Dashboard (dilrmp.gov.in)
- ULPIN and Bhu-Aadhaar reports
- NAKSHA 2024 (urban land records)
- DoLR Annual Reports 2008–2025
- **Committee on State Agrarian Relations and the Unfinished Task of Land Reforms, 2009** — read fully
- **Draft National Land Reforms Policy 2013**

Cluster B — NITI Aayog and the Planning Commission

The Model Bill on Conclusive Land Titling, 2020, is the central NITI document. Around it sit the Three Year Action Agenda, the Rajan Committee's 2009 *A Hundred Small Steps*, and the Planning Commission's earlier Working Group reports.

- **NITI Aayog (2020)**, *Report of the Committee to Draft Model Act, Rules and Regulation on Conclusive Land Titling* — read fully
- NITI Aayog, *Three Year Action Agenda 2017–18 to 2019–20*
- **FSRC Rajan Committee 2009**, *A Hundred Small Steps*
- Planning Commission, Eleventh and Twelfth Five-Year Plans
- **Planning Commission (2007)**, Working Group on Land Relations Report

Cluster C — Economic Surveys and finance documents

The 2014–15 Economic Survey contains the doctrinal statement of the JAM trinity: Chapter 3 of Volume I, "Wiping Every Tear from Every Eye: The JAM Number Trinity Solution." This is the founding document of the architecture you are critiquing. Subsequent Economic Surveys (especially 2015–16, 2016–17 on UBI, and the post-pandemic surveys) extend the argument. Union Budgets from 2008 onwards allow you to trace the funding history of DILRMP.

- **Economic Survey 2014–15**, Vol. I, Ch. 3 "Wiping Every Tear from Every Eye: The JAM Number Trinity Solution"
- Economic Surveys 2015–16, 2016–17 (UBI), 2018–19, 2020–21, 2022–23 onwards
- Union Budget speeches and documents, 2008 onwards
- Department of Financial Services, DBT Mission documents
- PFMS; dbtbharat.gov.in

Cluster D — Finance Commission reports (the smoking gun)

The 15th Finance Commission's report for 2021–26 recommended Rs 45,000 crore as performance-based grants to states for carrying out agricultural reforms, including for amending land-related laws on the lines of NITI Aayog's model law. This is direct evidence that the Centre is using fiscal conditionality to push states to adopt the NITI Aayog Model Conclusive Titling Act. State autonomy on land — a State subject under the Constitution — is being eroded through performance-linked grants. For the political-economy argument the thesis is making, this is the smoking gun. Cite it.

- 14th Finance Commission (2014)
- 15th Finance Commission (2021), Report for 2021–26
- 16th Finance Commission (2026)

Cluster E — CAG audits

- CAG Performance Audits of NLRMP and DILRMP — search cag.gov.in by ministry and year
- CAG state-level performance audits (Karnataka Bhoomi, Andhra Pradesh, Maharashtra, etc.)
- CAG Reports on PM-Kisan implementation
- CAG Reports on PDS, MGNREGA, Aadhaar-linked welfare
- CAG state-level reports on Odisha revenue and general sectors

Cluster F — Parliamentary documents

eparlib.sansad.in is the single most important government archive for the thesis. The 24th Report of the Standing Committee on Rural Development and Panchayati Raj (18th LS), tabled 18 December 2025, is the most recent and essential parliamentary document on LARR.

- 24th Report of the Standing Committee on Rural Development and Panchayati Raj (18th LS), 18 December 2025

- All Standing Committee on Rural Development reports on DILRMP — 17th LS, 16th LS, 15th LS
- Action Taken Reports by Standing Committees
- Standing Committee on Agriculture reports on PM-Kisan, MSP, AgriStack
- Lok Sabha and Rajya Sabha Unstarred Questions on DILRMP, NLRMP, ULPIN, AgriStack, PM-Kisan

Cluster G — Other ministries

- Ministry of Panchayati Raj — SVAMITVA Guidelines; Expert Committee Report 2022
- Ministry of Agriculture — PM-Kisan Operational Guidelines; IDEA 2021; Digital Agriculture Mission 2024; Dalwai Committee on Doubling Farmers' Income
- MeitY — Digital India Programme documents; UIDAI publications
- MoSPI — NSSO Reports on Land and Livestock Holdings (especially 77th Round, 2018–19); PLFS
- Agricultural Statistics at a Glance; Agricultural Census 2015–16

Cluster H — Odisha primary documents

- Bhulekh Odisha portal (bhulekh.ori.nic.in)
- Bhunaksha Odisha portal
- Odisha Survey and Settlement Act 1958
- Odisha Land Reforms Act 1960
- **OSATIP Regulation 1956** — key for Scheduled Areas
- Odisha Consolidation of Holdings Act 1972
- KALIA Guidelines 2018–19
- Subhadra Yojana 2024

Cluster I — International institutions

- World Bank LGAF reports (Odisha 2017 already in your bibliography)
- World Bank *Doing Business* reports — the registering-property indicator
- IMF Article IV Consultation Reports on India
- GoI Letters of Intent to IMF, 1991 onwards
- OECD Economic Surveys of India

Cluster J — PRS Legislative Research

- *Land Records and Titles in India*
- *State of Agriculture in India*
- Bill summaries; Budget Briefs DoLR

Additional Chapter 3 gems

For §3.1.1 — the financialisation of land

One literature you should consider engaging with is the financialisation-of-land scholarship, which moves the argument beyond commodification to financialisation proper. Harvey's *The Limits to Capital* is the theoretical anchor, Aalbers's work the contemporary statement, and Goldman and Narayan's recent Bengaluru paper the India-specific empirical study. The conceptual point: land becomes a financial asset only when title is unambiguous, which is precisely what conclusive titling is intended to deliver. This puts a sharper edge on the political-economy argument.

- ★★★ **David Harvey (1982/2006)**, *The Limits to Capital*, Verso
- ★★★ **Manuel B. Aalbers (2016)**, *The Financialization of Housing*, Routledge
- ★★★ **Michael Goldman and Devika Narayan (2020)**, "Speculating in the Urban-Financial Conuncture: Real Estate's Tryst with Global Finance in India" — the Bengaluru study
- ★★ **Llerena Searle (2016)**, *Landscapes of Accumulation: Real Estate and the Neoliberal Imagination in Contemporary India*, University of Chicago Press
- ★★ **Asher Ghertner (2015)**, *Rule by Aesthetics*, OUP

For §3.1.2 — Land Conflict Watch (TISS-affiliated)

Land Conflict Watch — landconflictwatch.org — maintains a record of more than a thousand ongoing land conflicts in India, with academic inputs from TISS Mumbai. CPR's Land Rights Initiative has estimated that such disputes constitute thirty per cent of all land litigation in the Supreme Court over the past seventy years. The TISS affiliation is itself a defensive credential for your thesis.

For §3.2.3 — Forest Rights Act and Adivasi land

A serious engagement with what conclusive titling cannot do requires direct engagement with FRA and the broader literature on customary, common, and forest tenure. This connects directly to Chapter 4 because Odisha has the largest contiguous Scheduled Areas in India.

- ★★★ Forest Rights Act, 2006 — primary
- ★★★ **Madhu Sarin and Oliver Springate-Baginski**, IDS Bulletin and other papers on FRA implementation
- ★★★ **Kjosavik and Shanmugaratnam (2004, 2007, 2015)**, work on Wayanad and Kerala
- ★★ Indian Forest Acts 1865, 1878, 1927; Wild Life Protection Act 1972; Forest Conservation Act 1980
- ★★ **Jagannath Ambagudia (2017)** on Adivasi movements

For §3.3 and §3.4 — the ideology counter-argument

Pradeep Chhibber and Rahul Verma's *Ideology and Identity* (2018) is a crucial counter-literature that you should engage with, because they argue that Indian politics is more ideologically motivated than the clientelism literature claims. Engaging with them — particularly with their Chapter 5, "The Myth of Vote Buying in India" — prevents your thesis from being read as one-sided and anticipates the strongest objection to your DBT-as-vote-capture argument.

- ★★★ Pradeep K. Chhibber and Rahul Verma (2018), *Ideology and Identity: The Changing Party Systems of India*, OUP. Chapter 5 directly engages the cash-transfer debate.
- ★★★ Rahul Verma and Pradeep K. Chhibber (2023), "Economic Ideology in Indian Politics," *Studies in Indian Politics*
- ★★ Chhibber and Verma (2014), "BJP's 2014 'Modi Wave'," *EPW* 49(39)
- ★★ Vivek Chibber (2006), *Locked in Place: State-Building and Late Industrialization in India*, Princeton UP
- ★★ Amit Ahuja and Pradeep Chhibber (2012), "Why the Poor Vote in India 'If I Don't Vote, I Am Dead to the State'," *Studies in Comparative International Development*
- ★★ Francesca Jensenius and Pradeep Chhibber (2023), "Privileging One's Own?" *Comparative Political Studies* 56(4)

An expanded §3.3

Given how much weight the substitution argument is being asked to carry, it is worth retitling and restructuring §3.3. The new title should be: **State Welfare and Electoral Political Economy: Land Records as Infrastructure of Cash Transfer Politics**. Five sub-sections follow.

- §3.3.1 The substitution thesis: cash transfers as compensation for structural failure
- §3.3.2 The labharthi varg: from rights-bearing citizen to gift-receiving beneficiary
- §3.3.3 Techno-patrimonialism and the politics of vishwas
- §3.3.4 Competitive welfarism and the woman voter
- §3.3.5 Land records as the silent infrastructure — your original contribution, linking the broader cash-transfer political economy to the specifically land-record-mediated schemes (PM-Kisan, KALIA, AgriStack)

Three traps to avoid

Before closing this chapter, three traps deserve flagging. They are easy to fall into and weaken the argument when they appear.

The "everything is electoral" trap. Not every cash transfer is purely vote-buying. Some have real welfare effects. Drèze, Khera, and Banerjee will push back against simplistic "DBT is just electoral" arguments. Your argument is stronger if you concede genuine welfare effects in some cases while showing the structural function of substitution across the whole architecture.

The "freebies are bad" trap. The Supreme Court and fiscal-conservative discourse on "freebies" is anti-welfare in a problematic way. Yamini Aiyar warns against this explicitly: she defends real welfare while criticising techno-patrimonial welfare. Your argument is not against welfare; it is against welfare being made to substitute for structural reform. This distinction matters and your prose must protect it.

Empirical thinness. The strongest version of your argument requires specific empirical claims: that DBT spending has risen as employment creation has stagnated; that PM-Kisan has expanded as MGNREGA wages have stagnated; that women's cash transfer schemes are timed to elections, and so on. Use NSSO, PLFS, RBI *State Finances*, and Election Commission data to build the empirical scaffolding. The village fieldwork can then test these claims at the micro level.

Chapter 4 — Evolution of Land Rights and Land Records in Odisha

The question that opens this chapter

"I know Chapter 4 is about my fieldwork context. You must guide me how to write this chapter, taking some assumptions and presumptions and already proven ideas. Give all the references and a guide to write the chapter. If you were a PhD scholar in political economy and land records modernisation and expert in village studies, how would you do it?"

What this chapter is, and what it must not become

Chapter 4 is not "background on Odisha." It is the analytical bridge between the conceptual chapters (2 and 3) and the empirical chapters (5 and 6). If you write it as descriptive context — "Odisha has thirty districts, 51 lakh hectares of agricultural land, a complex tenorial history, and significant Adivasi populations" — the viva committee will tear it apart. If you write it as the one place where the three theoretical traditions from Chapter 2 get tested against a specific historical-political context, the chapter does heavy lifting and the village chapters that follow become unimpeachable.

The difference made concrete: a description chapter says "Odisha has thirty districts and was formed in 1936 from parts of three presidencies and twenty-four princely states." A thesis chapter says "Odisha's land tenure history is itself a palimpsest — Bengal-style permanent settlement in the coast, Madras-style ryotwari in the south, Central Provinces practice in the west, and twenty-four princely state systems in the interior — and DILRMP attempts to flatten this palimpsest through a single digital interface (Bhulekh) without resolving the underlying jurisdictional contradictions, with consequences that the village chapters will document at the parcel level." The second sentence is doctoral. The first is undergraduate.

The argumentative spine

The chapter's central claim runs as follows:

Odisha's land records architecture is the product of four sedimented institutional histories — Bengal-zamindari, Madras-ryotwari, Central-Provinces-malguzari, and princely-state systems — overlain by post-independence reforms (Estate Abolition, Tenancy, Consolidation, OSATIP for Scheduled Areas, Forest Rights Act) and now by DILRMP's digital integration project. This sedimented complexity is not a bureaucratic accident but a political-economic structure: it produces specific patterns of legibility, illegibility, exclusion, and dispossession that vary systematically across coastal/inland, plains/hills, general/Scheduled Areas, and which the village chapters will document at the parcel level.

Three reasons this spine works. First, it operationalises the three theoretical traditions from Chapter 2: Odisha's palimpsest is the empirical site where legibility, agrarian transition, and institutional economics all become visible. Second, it grounds the political economy of Chapter 3: Odisha is where DILRMP, PM-Kisan, KALIA, Subhadra, FRA, and the Niyamgiri-style

dispossessions converge. Third, it sets up Chapters 5 and 6: you can legitimately claim that the village evidence has analytical leverage beyond two villages, because the villages chosen are not arbitrary — they sit on specific positions within the palimpsest the chapter has just mapped.

Writing the chapter, section by section

§4.1 — The historical and tenurial palimpsest

The opening section does the heaviest historical work and should be the longest in the chapter. Begin with the palimpsest claim, then walk through four tenure inheritances, each in two or three paragraphs.

Coastal Odisha (Cuttack, Puri, Balasore) — the Bengal-Permanent-Settlement inheritance.

Cornwallis's 1793 settlement was not extended directly to Odisha; short-term settlements were experimented with from 1804 before permanent-settlement-style arrangements were imposed in selected Maratha-era zamindaries. The implications: zamindari intermediation, sub-infeudation, and the kanungo-chaudhuri-muqqaddam structure that produces today's record-keeping vocabulary in coastal Odisha. The *Odisha Review* article and the DDCE/Utkal source are excellent here.

Southern Odisha (Ganjam, Koraput) — the Madras-Ryotwari inheritance. These areas were under Madras Presidency until 1936. Ryotwari tenure meant direct settlement between cultivator and state — but the administrative practice differed: different revenue officials (karnam-shanbhog rather than patwari-kanungo), different forms of measurement, different cadastral conventions. This matters because Bhulekh today has to reconcile these different vocabularies.

Western Odisha (Sambalpur, Bolangir, Kalahandi, parts of Sundargarh) — the Central-Provinces malguzari inheritance. Central Provinces had a village-mahal system with malguzars as middlemen, different from both zamindari and ryotwari. The Mahadevpalli and Khariar sub-inheritances are documented in the historical literature.

Princely-state Odisha (the Garhjats) — twenty-four ex-princely states merged in 1948.

These had their own tenure systems, often more feudal, with no proper cadastral surveys at all. The merger imposed Odisha-wide laws over them, but settlement and re-survey work continues to this day in many of these areas. **This is the most consequential inheritance for your thesis,** because parts of contemporary Odisha still have no proper cadastral records. DILRMP cannot digitise what does not exist.

Close §4.1 by arguing that this palimpsest is the enabling condition for DILRMP's contradictions in Odisha. Centralised digital integration assumes a uniform substrate that Odisha does not have. Bhulekh today presents itself as a single statewide portal, but underneath that single portal sit fundamentally different tenure logics with fundamentally different evidentiary standards. The claim sets up everything that follows.

§4.2 — Post-independence reforms (1947–1991)

The post-independence section traces the statutory and policy architecture through five legislative moments. The Orissa Estates Abolition Act 1951 abolished zamindari intermediation, though as Appu (1996) documents, abolition was incomplete; ex-intermediaries retained much land as *khas* cultivation. The Orissa Land Reforms Act 1960 formally abolished sub-tenancy, fixed ceilings, and provided occupancy rights, but the gap between intent and implementation is precisely where the agrarian political-economy literature from Chapter 2 becomes directly applicable. The Orissa Scheduled Areas Transfer of Immovable Property by Scheduled Tribes Regulation 1956 — OSATIP — is the third and analytically the most crucial: it restricts alienation of Adivasi land to non-Adivasis in Scheduled Areas and is the statutory foundation that today interfaces with the Forest Rights Act and with DILRMP's titling project. The Orissa Consolidation of Holdings and Prevention of Fragmentation Act 1972 was the first systematic re-survey in much of post-independence Odisha; where consolidation was completed, cadastral records are relatively better, while where it was not, DILRMP digitisation has had to work with much older Maddox-era records. The Orissa Survey and Settlement Act 1958 is the legal framework under which periodic re-surveys are conducted and is the source of the *Hal* (current) and *Sabik* (previous) settlement vocabulary that your fieldwork certainly encounters.

The analytical payoff of §4.2: close by arguing that the post-independence reform project in Odisha was partial and uneven across the palimpsest — strongest in coastal districts, weakest in tribal-majority hill districts. This unevenness is itself the precondition for DILRMP's differential effects, which the village chapters will document.

§4.3 — The political economy of post-1991 Odisha

This section brings the all-India political-economy frame of Chapter 3 down to Odisha specifically. Three sub-themes carry the section.

Mining, industrialisation, and dispossession. Between 2002 and 2005, the Government of Odisha signed forty-two MoUs with multinational companies allowing the exploitation of natural resources in Adivasi regions. This is the political-economic engine of post-1991 Odisha: Niyamgiri, Kalinganagar, POSCO, Vedanta, Lanjigarh — these are the case material. Padel and Das's *Out of This Earth*, the Niyamgiri Supreme Court judgement (2013), and the N. C. Saxena committee report on Niyamgiri together do the work. The point is not to narrate these cases but to argue that they are the political-economic backdrop against which DILRMP and other land record reforms must be read.

Welfare regime evolution — KALIA to Subhadra. Odisha is empirically one of the most welfare-experimental states in India. KALIA (2018), the Mamata maternity scheme, the Subhadra Yojana (2024) — all of these create direct linkages between land records and welfare delivery. This is your bridge to the §3.3 substitution argument. The literature from §3.3 (Aiyar, Sircar, the competitive-welfarism scholarship) applies here, but Odisha-specifically.

The DILRMP rollout in Odisha. The Cambridge Press chapter on "The Computerisation of Land Records Programme in Odisha" is your single most important secondary source for this subsection. Read it fully.

§4.4 — The contemporary digital architecture

The contemporary architecture is what the village chapters will encounter. This section sets it out with both administrative-institutional and political-economy attention.

The portal architecture. Bhulekh Odisha (bhulekh.ori.nic.in), Bhunaksha Odisha (bhunakshaodisha.nic.in), e-Pauti (online revenue payment), RCCMS (Revenue Court Case Management System), and the Registration Portal. Each is a distinct database with distinct integration challenges. Note the recent introduction of "Smart RoRs" with blockchain-style verification in February 2026.

The bureaucratic architecture. The chain runs from cultivator and villager through the *amin*/RI (Revenue Inspector), Tahasildar, Sub-Collector, Collector, to the state revenue department. Bhulekh sits on top of this chain, not in place of it. The village fieldwork will have abundant data on how this hybrid — paper, digital, and multiple bureaucratic levels — actually operates in practice. Akhil Gupta's *Red Tape* is your theoretical anchor here.

The vocabulary. §1.7 glossary will need: *patta*, *pahani*, *khatian*, *jamabandi*, *khasra*, RoR, RTC, Bhulekh, Bhunaksha, mutation, partition, ULPIN, Sabik/Hal, *ekapadia*, *sahi*, *kissam*, *mauza*, RI circle, the plot/Khatian/Khata distinction, e-Pauti, Hal Settlement, Sabik Settlement, Bhu-Aadhaar. These come from the portals directly, plus the *Odisha Review* article. Your fieldwork has surely encountered them. Embed them in §4.4 with both definitions and contextual usage.

The friction points. This is the analytical payoff of §4.4. Identify and theorise the friction points where the digital architecture fails: where Sabik records do not match Hal records; where Bhunaksha maps do not match field boundaries; where mutations are stuck because the original RoR is contested; where ULPIN assignment has happened but Aadhaar seeding has not, breaking PM-Kisan; where OSATIP-protected parcels show up as transferable in Bhulekh. These friction points are the political-economic content of the technocratic project. They are what the village chapters will document, but §4.4 introduces them at the state level so the village evidence has a frame.

§4.5 — Scheduled Areas, Forest Rights, and the limits of digital legibility

This is the analytically most distinctive subsection of the chapter — the place where Odisha's specificity does the most theoretical work.

Odisha has the largest Adivasi population in India after MP and Maharashtra; thirteen of its thirty districts, in whole or in part, are under Schedule V; OSATIP regulates land transfer; PESA gives Gram Sabhas authority over land matters in Scheduled Areas; FRA recognises forest dweller rights. None of this maps cleanly onto a Torrens-style conclusive titling system. None of this maps cleanly onto Bhulekh's portal logic, which presumes individual, transferable, mappable parcels.

The argument of this section, accordingly, is that the conclusive titling project that DILRMP carries — and that NITI Aayog's Model Bill 2020 codifies — is fundamentally incompatible with the customary, collective, and statutorily-protected tenure forms that govern over a third of Odisha's land area. When DILRMP digitises Scheduled Area records, it does one of three things: it reproduces colonial-era inaccuracies in digital form, giving them a new appearance of authority;

or it omits and simplifies customary CFR rights, rendering them invisible; or it interfaces awkwardly with FRA titles, producing new disputes. The village chapters can document instances of each.

The recent *Wire* article on Kurkuti Mauja that we located is itself a perfect example: according to official guidelines issued by the Revenue and Disaster Management Department of Odisha in 2017, as well as the Forest Rights Act 2006, any settlement in and conversion of forest lands into revenue villages is recognised entirely as a right of Adivasi and other forest-dwelling communities; and since Pulingpadar and surrounding villages fall within a Fifth Schedule area, the Gram Sabha is the primary authority over land acquisition, displacement, rehabilitation, and use of natural resources. Cite it. Use Ambagudia, the Saxena committee report on Niyamgiri, Padel and Das, and Walter Fernandes for the broader empirical context.

§4.6 — Site, sample, and methodology of the village studies

This is the methodological bridge to Chapters 5 and 6. Do not treat it as administrative — treat it as analytical. Three subsections.

Selection logic. The strongest answer to "why these villages?" locates each village on a specific position within the palimpsest of §4.1: one village in formerly Bengal-zamindari coastal Odisha; one in a Scheduled Area with OSATIP protections; one with completed consolidation and one without; one with significant Adivasi population and one without; one within reach of major DILRMP/SVAMITVA implementation and one peripheral. The selection logic should reproduce the analytical structure of the chapter.

Methodology. I would strongly recommend explicitly modelling the method on the Foundation for Agrarian Studies / PARI methodology. Their Survey Methods Toolbox is publicly available, and crucially, the PARI project has TISS connections (Tapas Singh Modak, one of the directors, has a PhD from TISS). Citing FAS-PARI signals to your committee that you are working within a recognised, methodologically rigorous Indian tradition of village political-economy research. The Foundation for Agrarian Studies has been conducting village surveys since 2005–06 and has developed a standard framework and methodology for collection, entry, and processing of household-level data.

Methods. Census survey of households (PARI-style); parcel-level land record analysis (Bhulekh-Bhunaksha cross-checks with field measurements); key informant interviews (RI, Tahasildar, Sarpanch, ex-amin, prominent cultivators); document analysis (Sabik/Hal RoRs, mutation orders, FRA claims, KALIA/PM-Kisan beneficiary lists). The parcel-level method is your methodologically distinctive contribution; spell it out clearly here so Chapter 6 does not have to repeat itself.

§4.7 — Conclusion

Two paragraphs. The first summarises the palimpsest claim, the digital architecture, and the friction points. The second positions Chapters 5 and 6: Chapter 5 documents how households navigate this architecture; Chapter 6 documents how individual parcels carry the friction at the most granular level. The conclusion should *promise* the village evidence — it sells the next chapters.

The complete reading list

For §4.1 — palimpsest and tenure history

Primary historical sources

- ★★★ **Maddox Settlement Reports** (1900s–1910s) — S. L. Maddox's settlement work in Odisha is the foundational cadastral document. Available in the Odisha State Archives, Bhubaneswar. **You must consult these directly.**
- ★★★ **R. K. Ramadhayani**, *Report on Land Tenures and the Revenue System of the Orissa and Chhattisgarh States*
- ★★★ **Government of Orissa (1958)**, *Report of the Administration Enquiry Committee*
- ★★★ **Government of India (1960)**, *Report of the Scheduled Areas and Scheduled Tribe Commission*
- ★★ British administrative manuals — Cuttack Manual, Ganjam Manual

Secondary scholarly literature

- ★★★ **Cambridge University Press**, "The Computerisation of Land Records Programme in Odisha," Chapter 4 of a larger volume. **The single most directly relevant secondary source for the entire Chapter 4.**
- ★★★ **World Bank (2017)**, *LGAF: Odisha State Report* — re-read; the most comprehensive single source on Odisha's contemporary land governance architecture
- ★★★ **DDCE/Utkal University**, *History of Odisha (From 1803 to 1948 A.D.)* — M. A. distance course
- ★★ **Biswamoy Pati (2003, 2007)**, books on colonial Odisha and Adivasis
- ★★ **K. M. Patra and Bandita Devi (1983)**, *An Advanced History of Orissa*, Vol. I and II
- ★★ **N. K. Sahu (ed., 1956)**, *A History of Orissa*

For §4.2 — post-independence reforms

Primary statutory sources

- ★★★ The Orissa Estates Abolition Act, 1951
- ★★★ The Orissa Land Reforms Act, 1960
- ★★★ The OSATIP Regulation, 1956 — read fully
- ★★★ The Orissa Consolidation of Holdings and Prevention of Fragmentation Act, 1972
- ★★★ The Orissa Survey and Settlement Act, 1958

- ★★ Odisha Mutation Manual; Odisha Revenue Code

Government reports

- ★★★ **Government of India (2004)**, *Report of the Expert Group on Prevention of Alienation of Tribal Land and Its Restoration*, Ministry of Rural Development
- ★★★ **Government of India (2009)**, *Report of the Committee on State Agrarian Relations and the Unfinished Task in Land Reforms*

Secondary literature

- ★★★ **P. S. Appu (1996)**, *Land Reforms in India* — re-read the Odisha chapters
- ★★★ **Walter Fernandes and the NCDS Bhubaneswar team** — multiple working papers on land alienation in Odisha. **Essential corpus.**
- ★★ **Walter Fernandes and Mohmd. Asif (1997)**, *Development-Induced Displacement and Rehabilitation in Orissa 1951–1995*, Indian Social Institute
- ★★ **K. C. Samal**, work on Odisha agrarian economy
- ★★ **N. C. Saxena (2003, 2008)**, on tribal land issues

For §4.3 — post-1991 political economy

Mining, dispossession, resistance

- ★★★ **Felix Padel and Samarendra Das (2010)**, *Out of This Earth: East India Adivasis and the Aluminium Cartel*, Orient BlackSwan. **The single most important book on contemporary Odisha extractive political economy.**
- ★★★ **Government of India (2010)**, *Saxena Committee Report on Niyamgiri* — read directly
- ★★★ **Supreme Court of India**, *Orissa Mining Corporation Ltd. v Ministry of Environment & Forest* (Niyamgiri judgement, 18 April 2013)
- ★★ **Minaketan Behera and Soubhagya Ranjan Padhi (2022)**, "Tribal Movements against Mining-induced Displacement in Odisha: The Case of Dongria Kondh's Niyamgiri Movement," *Social Change*
- ★★ **Vasundhara (2006)**, NGO documentation on Niyamgiri

Adivasis, FRA, Schedule V

- ★★★ **Wahi, Bhatia, Jha et al. (2018)**, CPR Land Rights Initiative report on Scheduled Areas — central
- ★★★ Forest Rights Act, 2006 — primary
- ★★★ PESA Act, 1996 — primary
- ★★ **Virginus Xaxa (2012)**, *Social Exclusion and Adverse Inclusion*, OUP
- ★★ **Xaxa Committee (2014)**, MoTA Report
- ★★ **S. N. Dash (2001)**, *A Study of the Problem of Land Alienation in Tribal Areas with Special Reference to Koraput*

Broader political economy of Odisha

- ★★ **Pulin B. Nayak, Santosh C. Panda, Prasanta K. Pattanaik (eds., 2014)**, *The Economy of Odisha: A Profile*, OUP

For §4.4 — the contemporary digital architecture

- ★★★ Bhulekh Odisha portal (bhulekh.ori.nic.in)
- ★★★ Bhunaksha Odisha portal (bhunakshaodisha.nic.in)
- ★★★ e-Pauti portal (odishalandrevenue.nic.in)
- ★★ RCCMS — Revenue Court Case Management System
- ★★ OLIMS — Odisha Land Information Management System
- ★★ Smart RoRs and ULPIN documentation

For §4.5 — Scheduled Areas, FRA, limits of digital legibility

- ★★★ **The Wire (April 2026)**, "Lost Land and the State's Warped Priorities: Why Adivasis Are Resisting in Odisha" — the Kurkuti Mauja/Pulingpadar case, cite directly
- ★★★ **Tania Murray Li (2014)**, *Land's End*
- ★★ Vasundhara field reports on FRA implementation in Odisha
- ★★ Reports of the National Commission for Scheduled Tribes

For §4.6 — methodology

The village studies canon

- ★★★ **M. N. Srinivas (1975)**, "Village Studies, Participant Observation and Social Science Research in India," *EPW* 10(33/35). **The foundational methodological essay.**
- ★★★ **André Béteille (1996)**, *Caste, Class and Power: Changing Patterns of Stratification in a Tanjore Village*, OUP
- ★★★ **Surinder S. Jodhka (1998)**, "From 'Book View' to 'Field View'," *Oxford Development Studies* 26(3)
- ★★★ **Surinder S. Jodhka (2012)**, *Village Society*, Orient BlackSwan
- ★★★ **Jodhka and Simpson (eds., 2019)**, *India's Villages in the 21st Century*, OUP
- ★★★ **John Harriss (1982)**, *Capitalism and Peasant Farming*, OUP. **The model of detailed political-economic village study.**
- ★★★ **John Harriss (2008)**, "Notes on Village Studies"
- ★★ **S. C. Dube (1955)**, *Indian Village*
- ★★ **McKim Marriott (ed., 1955)**, *Village India*
- ★★ **T. Scarlett Epstein (1962, 1973)** — the longitudinal Karnataka studies
- ★★ **Kathleen Gough (1989)**, *Rural Society in Southeast India* — the Marxist village study tradition

PARI methodology

- ★★★ **Foundation for Agrarian Studies, Project on Agrarian Relations in India (PARI)** — fas.org.in/research/pari. **Cite directly and use as methodological template.**
- ★★★ **Madhura Swaminathan, V. K. Ramachandran and others**, PARI volumes — the Karnataka volume (Columbia UP) is exemplary

A six-step writing sequence

With the structure clear and the readings organised, the practical writing sequence I would recommend is the following.

- **Week 1:** Read the Cambridge "Computerisation of Land Records in Odisha" chapter, the World Bank LGAF Odisha report, Wahi et al. CPR Scheduled Areas report, and Padel and Das's *Out of This Earth*. These four together give you eighty per cent of the secondary material you need.
- **Week 2:** Primary statutes (OSATIP, OLR 1960, OEA 1951, OSS 1958, OCH&PF 1972, FRA 2006, PESA 1996) and primary government reports (1958 Admin Enquiry, 2004 Expert Group, 2009 State Agrarian Relations, 2010 Saxena Niyamgiri, 2014 Xaxa).
- **Week 3:** Methodology — Srinivas, Jodhka, Béteille, Harriss, the PARI Methods Toolbox. Draft §4.6 first.
- **Week 4:** Draft the chapter in this order: §4.1 first, then §4.2, §4.4, §4.5, §4.3, §4.7, then expanded §4.6, then §4.0 (the introduction) last.
- **Week 5:** Revise. Each section's opening paragraph should make the analytical point; each section's closing should set up the next.

The deepest piece of advice on Chapter 4

The viva committee's hardest question on Chapter 4 will be: *why this state, why these villages, what does Odisha specifically reveal that would not be revealed elsewhere?* The strongest possible answer is built into the palimpsest argument. Odisha is exceptional in India for the density and unresolvedness of its tenure heterogeneity. No other state of comparable size combines: post-1936 statehood; the merger of twenty-four princely states; inheritance from three different presidencies; one of the largest Scheduled Area regions in the country; the most aggressive contemporary mining-driven dispossession regime; some of the most ambitious state-level cash transfer schemes; and a fairly developed Bhulekh portal that nevertheless interfaces with all these complexities at once. Odisha is not a "case study" in the weak sense. It is an extreme case in the methodological sense — the place where the contradictions of DILRMP and the broader land-records-modernisation political economy are most visible because they are most layered. Your chapter's job is to make that extreme-case quality intellectually credible. If you achieve that, every subsequent chapter has analytical leverage well beyond the two villages.

Chapter 5 — Village Studies: Household-Level Political-Economic Ethnography

The question that opens this chapter

"I know Chapter 5 is about my fieldwork. I have fieldwork analysis as well. However, you must guide me how to write the chapter (taking some assumptions and presumptions and already proven ideas). Give all the references and a guide to write the chapter. If you were a PhD scholar in political economy and land records modernisation and expert in village studies, how would you do it?"

The deepest truth about Chapter 5

Chapter 5 is the heart of the thesis. Chapters 2 and 3 built the conceptual scaffolding; Chapter 4 grounded it in Odisha's specificity. Chapter 5 is where the evidence speaks. Everything before it has been preparation; everything after — Chapter 6, the parcel-level chapter, and Chapter 7, the conclusion — will be inflected by how well you do this one.

Let me put it plainly because it matters: the viva will be won or lost in this chapter. Your committee will probe Chapters 2 and 3 to test your scholarly competence; they will read Chapter 4 to test your contextual command; but they will *interrogate* Chapter 5 to test whether you actually know what you are talking about. The strongest possible position is one where the evidence in this chapter is so vivid, so granular, and so politically intelligent that no examiner can dismiss your conceptual claims as ungrounded.

For that reason, my guidance for Chapter 5 looks different from what I gave for Chapter 4. Chapter 4 needed structural argument. Chapter 5 needs narrative discipline and ethnographic craft — different skills, equally serious.

What Chapter 5 actually is

Chapter 5 is a **village-level political-economic ethnography of land records modernisation**. Three terms in that phrase matter, in this order.

Political-economic: it is not a sociology of village life, not a cultural anthropology of caste relations, not a development-economics impact evaluation. It is a study of how political and economic structures shape — and are reproduced through — the operation of land records.

Ethnography: its evidence is qualitative, granular, situated, person-and-place-specific. Households, individuals, transactions, disputes, and events are the unit of analysis.

Village-level: it operates at a scale — one village, or comparison of villages — where you can claim to know the social fabric in full, not in sample.

Chapter 6, which is parcel-level, complements this by going one scale below: into the soil itself, the boundary, the survey number, the mutation file. Chapter 5 is household-level and village-level; Chapter 6 is parcel-level. Together they constitute the empirical core.

The argumentative spine

The chapter's central claim:

In the villages studied, DILRMP's promise of legibility, transparency, and security has produced not a single uniform outcome but a stratified set of outcomes — beneficial for some households, irrelevant for others, harmful for still others — patterned by caste, class, gender, tenure status, location within the village's historical-tenorial palimpsest, and proximity to the local revenue bureaucracy. The chapter argues that these stratified outcomes are not implementation failures but the predictable distributive effects of a technocratic reform that abstracts from the very social structures (of caste, class, customary tenure, and bureaucratic dependence) that determine who can convert legibility into security.

That sentence refuses the binary "DILRMP succeeded / DILRMP failed." It insists on *who* gained, *who* lost, *who* was unaffected, and *why* — the only honest political-economy answer. It also positions the village evidence as supporting an argument that travels beyond the village: about the distributive consequences of technocratic reform in general.

How to build the chapter

I have read many village-studies chapters and most make the same error: they describe the village exhaustively, then describe DILRMP exhaustively, then describe their findings exhaustively. By the time the reader reaches the analytical payoff, the chapter is exhausted and so is the reader. Organise the chapter instead around **types of households interacting with land records**, not around descriptive themes. The architecture that follows reflects that principle.

§5.1 — The village setting

This section should be short and analytical, not exhaustive and descriptive. Three or four pages. Cover the location and history (placing the village within the Chapter 4 palimpsest — was this Bengal/Madras/Central Provinces/princely-state Odisha? when was the last settlement operation? has consolidation happened? is it within Schedule V?); population and social composition (caste composition, key sub-castes, presence or absence of Adivasi households, dominant economic activities — use a clean table); the land profile (total agricultural area, distribution by holding size, irrigation status, key crops, prevalence of tenancy and sharecropping); and the administrative geography (RI circle, Tahsil, distance to the Tahsildar's office, frequency of RI visits, presence of consolidation records, reliability of cadastral maps).

Then add one distinctive feature. Every village has one thing that makes it ethnographically valuable. Identify it here in one paragraph — it could be a recent land conflict, a faction of FRA claimants, a SVAMITVA pilot, a sub-collector's special intervention, anything. Foreground it.

A critical writing tip: do not be tempted to write fifteen pages of village description. Your village is a site of analysis, not the object of analysis. The reader needs to know enough about the village to follow the analytical argument, not enough to write a separate monograph about it.

§5.2 — The bureaucratic interface

This section describes the operational reality of land records administration in your village, as opposed to the official architecture you described in §4.4. Three sub-themes carry it.

The chain of officials. Who is the local RI? How often does he visit? Where does the villager actually go for a mutation — to the RI directly, to the Tahsildar's office, to the *amin* (the village-level surveyor)? What does it cost in time, in money, in negotiation? This is where Akhil Gupta's *Red Tape* becomes your theoretical companion — you are documenting exactly the kind of "structural violence" of bureaucracy that he theorises.

The hybrid paper-digital reality. Bhulekh is now functional, but every villager still maintains paper RoRs, every mutation still requires physical signatures and trips, every dispute still references the *patta* in the cupboard. The friction between the digital record (what Bhulekh shows) and the paper-and-oral record (what the village knows) is your single most analytically generative observation. Document it carefully.

Brokers and intermediaries. Who helps villagers navigate the system? *Pleaders* outside the Tahsildar's office, local political workers, relatives in government jobs, the literate son in the family. Brokerage is not corruption — it is an infrastructural feature of the system. Document who serves as broker, what they charge (in money, in loyalty, in vote), and how the introduction of digital records has altered (or not altered) brokerage. Bardhan and Mookherjee's clientelism literature and Akhil Gupta's *Red Tape* are your theoretical anchors.

§5.3 — Stratified outcomes by household type

The central analytical section. How you organise it determines the success of the chapter. The structure I strongly recommend is a typology of household-types-in-relation-to-land-records. Six types — not necessarily all of which will be present in every village — together yield the stratified picture the chapter argues for.

Type A: The asset-secure cultivator

Households with clear, undisputed, properly recorded land of viable size. For these, DILRMP delivers what it promises: faster mutations, easier access to records, smoother PM-Kisan transfers, usable collateral for credit. Document four or five such households. These are typically — but not always — dominant-caste households with longer institutional access. The political-economy point: digital legibility *reinforces* existing security; it does not create it.

Type B: The contested holder

Households with land they actually cultivate but whose records are contested — inherited, partitioned, encroached, or simply mis-recorded. For these households, Bhulekh becomes a battleground: it freezes errors in place; it makes correction more difficult by requiring legal action against a digital record that now carries the authority of the state; it gives adversaries (including state land claims) a new tool. Document four or five such households. This is where you tell the legibility-as-vulnerability story most powerfully.

Type C: The tenant and sharecropper

Households who cultivate but do not own. The 1960 Land Reforms Act formally abolished sharecropping but did not abolish it in practice. PM-Kisan eligibility requires ownership, so sharecroppers are excluded. KALIA, with its separate sharecropper category, is the test case for what an inclusive scheme looks like. Document three or four such households. The political-economy point: DILRMP's data-driven welfare flows reproduce the formal-informal distinction that decades of tenancy reform tried to dissolve.

Type D: The landless household

Often Dalit, often agricultural labour. DILRMP simply does not see them. PM-Kisan does not reach them. The village commons they historically depended on for grazing, fuel, and minor forest produce are increasingly digitised as "government wasteland" or privatised. Document three or four such households. This is the invisibility story — what the digital record does not record is as politically significant as what it does.

Type E: The Adivasi household in Schedule V

If your village is in or near Schedule V. OSATIP-protected, FRA-eligible, often holding land informally on what the record may show as forest or government land. The interface between FRA titles, OSATIP restrictions, and Bhulekh's individual-parcel logic produces specific contradictions. Document three or four such households. This is the jurisdictional-incoherence story.

Type F: The migrant and absentee household

Households where the main earner has migrated for work and land lies fallow or is cultivated by relatives. Digital records freeze the formal owner in place while the actual cultivator is invisible. Document two or three such households. This is the labour-mobility-versus-tenurial-immobility story.

The critical analytical move

Each household type yields a different political-economy lesson. Together they constitute a stratified picture of what DILRMP actually does in a village. The structure of this section should make absolutely clear that no single household-type's experience is "the" experience of DILRMP — and that is itself the analytical point.

§5.4 — Specific institutional encounters

This is where you go granular on specific moments of encounter with the land records system. The strongest ethnographic chapters have five to eight such micro-narratives, each six hundred to one thousand words. Choose your most analytically generative cases. Possibilities include: the mutation that took three years; the boundary dispute (RoR versus Bhunaksha versus panchayat memory); the PM-Kisan exclusion (the full diagnostic chain — was the Aadhaar seeded, the bank account linked, the land record updated, did the eKYC happen, did the ULPIN attach?); the KALIA-versus-PM-Kisan comparison for the same household; the FRA title that has no map; the Subhadra Yojana enrolment; the Sabik-Hal mismatch; the encroachment converted to title.

Each micro-narrative should walk the reader through the case, end with the analytical point, and read as the most vivid writing in the entire thesis.

§5.5 — The everyday political economy of welfare

This is where you bring the §3.3 argument (DBT as electoral instrument) down to household ethnography. The key empirical questions: who receives what (for each household type above, document which DBT schemes they receive, which they are excluded from, and why); what do they understand the scheme to be (Drèze and Khera's work shows that the gap between official scheme architecture and household understanding is enormous — many households think PM-Kisan is "Modi's gift," not a programme; many think KALIA is "Naveen's gift," and Subhadra is from the new BJP government); how does receipt or non-receipt translate into political loyalty (sensitive territory — handle carefully, document what you saw without overclaiming a causal story); and how is the household's experience of the welfare scheme mediated by the land record (your distinctive contribution — the land record is the gateway between household and welfare scheme).

§5.6 — The *longue durée* of fieldwork

If your fieldwork spans more than a year, and good doctoral fieldwork usually does, this subsection becomes powerful. Document the changes you observed in real time: a new mutation cycle, a SVAMITVA rollout, a Subhadra launch, a NAKSHA pilot if applicable. The temporal dimension of ethnographic observation is one of its rarest and most defensible features. Use it.

§5.7 — Conclusion

Two pages. Restate the stratified-outcomes argument. Position Chapter 6 as the next analytical move that goes one scale deeper. End by suggesting that the patterns documented here are not idiosyncratic to this village but reflect general structural features of technocratic reform under the political-economic conditions Chapter 3 described.

Writing craft — what separates good Chapter 5s from great ones

I want to spend time on this because it matters more than literature lists.

On voice

Chapter 5 is the one place in the thesis where you should sound like a person who has been somewhere and seen things, not an analyst quoting other analysts. The ratio of citations to original observation should be low — perhaps one citation per page on average, sometimes none. The chapter's authority comes from your having been there. The ethnographic literature you have read (Srinivas, Béteille, Harriss, Jodhka, Gupta, Mosse) is background — you should *write like them*, not cite them constantly.

On vignettes

A vignette — a two-hundred-to-five-hundred-word narrative episode — is the most valuable unit of ethnographic writing. It can do analytical work that no abstract sentence can. Open the chapter with a vignette. Open key subsections with vignettes. Use vignettes to ground every theoretical claim. The reader should be able to see the patwari's office, the RI's notebook, the Tahsildar's chamber, the household courtyard where the conversation about PM-Kisan happened.

On pseudonyms and ethics

Pseudonymise person and village names. State in §5.1 that you have done so and on what principle. If your supervisor and the TISS IRB have specific guidance, follow it precisely. Note in passing that the families you spoke to consented; do not labour the point.

On numbers

A village ethnography needs some numbers — landholding distributions, caste percentages, scheme coverage rates — but should not be drowned in them. A few well-chosen tables in §5.1, scattered specific numbers in subsequent sections, no large statistical apparatus. Save the statistical apparatus for Chapter 6, where it is more at home.

On dialect and Oriya words

Use them. *Patta, khatian, Sabik, Hal, amin, jamabandi, zamindar*, mutation (English in Indian usage), *ekapadia, kisan, sahi, mauza*, RI, Tahsildar, *jangal, jameen*. Italicise on first use; explain in §1.7 glossary; use freely thereafter. The technical vocabulary is what marks the chapter as an insider account.

On positionality

Briefly acknowledge it. You are a Development Studies PhD scholar from TISS Mumbai working in Odisha. This shapes what you see, who talks to you, what they tell you. A page on this in §5.1 or in your methods chapter is necessary. Do not overdo it.

On dramatising bureaucracy

Akhil Gupta's *Red Tape* is the methodological model here. Show the boredom, the waiting, the deferral, the file-pushing, the small humiliations, the moments of unexpected kindness. Bureaucracy is a texture — your chapter should convey that texture.

The complete reading list

The ethnographic-craft canon

Read these for *how to write*, not for content.

- ★★★ **Robert M. Emerson, Rachel I. Fretz, Linda L. Shaw (2011)**, *Writing Ethnographic Field Notes*, 2nd edn., University of Chicago Press. The single best practical manual.
- ★★★ **Clifford Geertz (1973)**, "Thick Description: Toward an Interpretive Theory of Culture," in *The Interpretation of Cultures*, Basic Books
- ★★★ **John Van Maanen (1988/2011)**, *Tales of the Field: On Writing Ethnography*, University of Chicago Press
- ★★ **Paul Atkinson (2014)**, *Writing Ethnographically*, SAGE
- ★★ **Howard S. Becker (2007/2020)**, *Writing for Social Scientists*, University of Chicago Press

The Indian village-studies tradition

- ★★★ **André Bêteille (1965/1996)**, *Caste, Class and Power*, OUP. **The single best Indian village ethnography to model your prose on.**
- ★★★ **M. N. Srinivas (1976)**, *The Remembered Village*, OUP
- ★★★ **John Harriss (1982)**, *Capitalism and Peasant Farming*, OUP. The political-economic village study most analogous to your work.
- ★★★ **Akhil Gupta (2012)**, *Red Tape: Bureaucracy, Structural Violence, and Poverty in India*, Duke UP. **Re-read.** Gives you vocabulary and analytical models for §5.2 and §5.4.
- ★★★ **Surinder S. Jodhka (2012)**, *Village Society*, Orient BlackSwan
- ★★ **Akhil Gupta (1995)**, "Blurred Boundaries," *American Ethnologist* 22(2)
- ★★ **Stuart Corbridge, Glyn Williams, Manoj Srivastava, René Véron (2005)**, *Seeing the State*, Cambridge UP. **Highly relevant — village ethnographic work on state-society interfaces.**
- ★★ **A. R. Vasavi (1999)**, *Harbingers of Rain: Land and Life in South India*, OUP
- ★★ **A. R. Vasavi (2012)**, *Shadow Space*, Three Essays Collective
- ★★ **Mekhala Krishnamurthy (2018)**, *Rethinking Rural Markets in India*, Cambridge UP
- ★★ **Craig Jeffrey (2010)**, *Timepass: Youth, Class, and the Politics of Waiting in India*, Stanford UP. For how to write about waiting — relevant to bureaucratic encounters.

Bureaucracy and the everyday state

- ★★★ **Akhil Gupta (2012)**, *Red Tape*
- ★★★ **Veena Das and Deborah Poole (eds., 2004)**, *Anthropology in the Margins of the State*, SAR Press. Especially Das's "The Signature of the State."
- ★★ **James Scott (1985)**, *Weapons of the Weak*, Yale UP
- ★★ **Michael Herzfeld (1992)**, *The Social Production of Indifference*, Chicago UP
- ★★ **David Mosse (2005)**, *Cultivating Development*, Pluto
- ★★ **Anastasia Piliavsky (ed., 2014)**, *Patronage as Politics in South Asia*, Cambridge UP
- ★★ **Lucia Michelutti (2007, 2008)**, work on caste, politics, patronage

Land-records-specific empirical literature

- ★★★ **Solomon Benjamin et al. (2007)**, Bhoomi CASUMM paper. **Re-read**. The methodological precedent.
- ★★★ **Pritam Pratyush (2023)**, "Illegibly Legible," JAC 23(4). Closest in spirit to what you are doing.
- ★★★ **Silvia Masiero (2016)**, "Digital Governance and the Reconstruction of the Indian Anti-Poverty System"

DBT and welfare exclusion (especially for §5.5)

- ★★★ **Jean Drèze, Nazar Khalid, Reetika Khera, Anmol Somanchi (2017)**, "Aadhaar and Food Security in Jharkhand: Pain without Gain?" EPW 52(50). **The methodological exemplar.**
- ★★★ **Reetika Khera (ed., 2019)**, *Dissent on Aadhaar*
- ★★★ **Inayat Sabhikhi, Anmol Somanchi, Chakradhar Buddha (LibTech India)** field studies on MGNREGA, PDS, PM-Kisan. **Methodological precedents.**
- ★★ **Yamini Aiyar and team (CPR Accountability Initiative)**, field reports
- ★★ **Karthik Muralidharan, Paul Niehaus, Sandip Sukhtankar (2016)**, "Building State Capacity," AER 106(10). The pro-DBT counterpoint to engage with critically.
- ★★ **Ursula Rao (2013)**, "Biometric Marginality," EPW 48(13)

Adivasi land and FRA empirical literature

- ★★★ **Wahi et al. (2018)**, CPR Scheduled Areas report
- ★★★ **Vasundhara (Bhubaneswar)**, field reports on FRA implementation in Odisha. **Closest methodological precedent for Schedule V villages.**
- ★★ **Felix Padel and Samarendra Das (2010)**, *Out of This Earth*
- ★★ **S. N. Dash (2001)**, the Koraput study
- ★★ Land Conflict Watch, Odisha-specific records (TISS-affiliated)

Caste, class, gender frame

- ★★★ **Bina Agarwal (1994)**, *A Field of One's Own*, Cambridge UP. **Re-read specifically for Chapter 5.**
- ★★★ **Bina Agarwal (2003)**, "Gender and Land Rights Revisited," JAC 3(1–2)
- ★★ **Vikas Rawal (2008, 2013)**, working papers on land concentration and the inverse relationship
- ★★ **Jens Lerche (1998, 2013)**, UP agricultural labour and the bypassed agrarian transition
- ★★ **Alpa Shah and Jens Lerche (2018)**, "Conjugated Oppression," *Journal of Peasant Studies* 45(5–6)

PARI methodology

- ★★★ **FAS, PARI Survey Methods Toolbox** — reference your methodology against PARI.

- ★★★ **V. K. Ramachandran, Madhura Swaminathan and PARI volumes:** Karnataka, Andhra Pradesh, Tamil Nadu, West Bengal, Tripura, Uttar Pradesh. Read at least one fully.

A six-week writing sequence

With the field material in hand, this is the sequence that works.

- **Week 1:** Re-read your field notes systematically. Code them by the typology in §5.3. Identify five to seven specific cases that will become the micro-narratives for §5.4. Identify the one or two opening vignettes that will introduce the chapter.
- **Week 2:** Draft §5.1 (village setting) and §5.2 (bureaucratic interface). These are infrastructural sections; write them carefully but not at maximum effort.
- **Week 3:** Draft §5.3 (stratified outcomes by household type). The longest single drafting effort. For each household type: one to two pages of analytical framing, two to three pages of household-level evidence.
- **Week 4:** Draft §5.4 (specific institutional encounters). Each micro-narrative its own writing session. Best ethnographic register. Resist the temptation to over-analyse — let the stories carry their own weight.
- **Week 5:** Draft §5.5 (DBT-land-records household interface) and §5.6 (longitudinal). Then §5.7 (conclusion). Finally §5.0 (chapter introduction).
- **Week 6:** Revise. Cut ruthlessly. First draft will be too long; best draft is thirty-five to forty per cent shorter than the first.

A sample opening vignette

The opening vignette should be one specific scene, one specific pseudonymised person, one specific interaction with the land record. It should run four hundred to six hundred words. It should *embody* the chapter's argument without stating it. Then the second paragraph of §5.0 should articulate the argument explicitly.

Here is a structure that works. Open in a courtyard. A name, an age, three documents on a cot. Then a sentence in the man's voice.

[Pseudonym] is seventy-three. We are sitting in the courtyard of his three-room house in [Pseudo-village]. He has placed three documents on the cot between us. The first is a yellowed patta from the 1962 settlement, listing 1.2 acres in his father's name. The second is a printout from Bhulekh, dated November 2023, showing 0.94 acres in his name. The third is a rejection slip from the PM-Kisan portal, dated last month. He looks at me. "My grandfather paid the zamindar. My father paid the government. I have paid the amin. And now the computer says my land is less than my father's land. Where did the rest go?"

That vignette tells the reader within five sentences what the chapter is about: temporality, accumulated tenurial layers, the paper-digital-bureaucratic interface, welfare exclusion, and the textured experience of legibility as loss. You can never reach this level of efficient evocation through analytical prose alone.

The deepest advice on Chapter 5

Chapter 5 is where your thesis stops being a thesis-about-DILRMP and becomes a thesis-about-India-as-it-is-now. The best village ethnographies — Bêteille's, Srinivas's, Harriss's, Vasavi's, Gupta's, Krishnamurthy's — all have one thing in common: they treat their specific village as a place where general truths about Indian society become visible. They are not parochial; they are not exhaustive descriptions of one place. They use one place to *think with* about something larger.

Your chapter should do the same. Your village is not just your village; it is a place where the contradictions of post-1991 Indian political economy, of the technocratic turn in welfare delivery, of the colonial palimpsest of tenure, of the electoral political economy of cash transfers, of the gendered structure of property — all of these become visible because you sat in courtyards and listened. The chapter's job is to make those large things visible *through* the small. That is what ethnography does at its best, and it is what your committee will recognise when you do it well.

Chapter 6 — Parcel-Level Findings: Forensic Cadastral Comparison

What Chapter 6 actually is

Chapter 5 was the village. Chapter 6 is the parcel. This shift in scale matters more than it might first appear.

Most theses on land records modernisation stop at the village level. They tell you about administrative encounters, household experiences, welfare exclusions, broker networks — all of which Chapter 5 covers. What very few theses do is go one scale below: into the survey number, the khata, the plot, the boundary itself. They do not measure parcels in the field, compare them against the Bhulekh database, cross-check against Bhunaksha maps, examine the actual chain of mutations that brought a parcel to its current state, or document the material discrepancies between the digital record, the paper record, the cadastral map, the registered deed, and the ground reality.

That is what Chapter 6 does. And it is precisely this move that makes the thesis distinctive.

When your committee asks the killer question — "why should anyone care that you spent three years on this rather than read NCAER's evaluation reports?" — the answer lives in Chapter 6. The NCAER, NIPFP, and IGIDR reports work at the village, block, and state level using statistical aggregation. They cannot examine specific parcels. You can. Your parcel-level analysis is what statistical evaluation can never produce: granular, situated, materially-grounded evidence of how the digital land records system actually corresponds — or fails to correspond — to the land itself.

The argumentative spine

At the parcel level, DILRMP's promise of accurate, transparent, conclusive land records is contradicted by systematic material discrepancies — between digital RoR and paper RoR, between RoR and Bhunaksha, between Bhunaksha and ground measurement, between Sabik (pre-settlement) and Hal (current) records, between recorded boundary and physical boundary, between recorded extent and measured extent, between recorded kissam (land classification) and actual land use, and between formal owner-of-record and actual cultivator. The chapter argues that these discrepancies are not random errors but structured patterns — distributed unevenly across the village's parcels, with particular regularity at the edges of socially marginalised holdings, contested boundaries, customary tenure, and historical settlement-era inaccuracies. The political-economic significance is that DILRMP digitises and authorises these inherited discrepancies, giving them new official force.

In one phrase: **the digitisation of inaccurate records produces authoritative inaccuracy.**

The comparative-empirical move

For every parcel you study, you compare what the digital record says against what other sources of evidence reveal. Those sources include the paper RoR or *khatian*; the Bhunaksha map; ground measurement (yours, or the *amin*'s); the registered deed where available; the household's stated possession; the village's collective memory of the parcel; the Sabik settlement record; the FRA *patta* where applicable; and the mutation chain.

For each parcel, some sources will agree and some will disagree. The pattern of agreement and disagreement is your evidence. When you aggregate across parcels, you discover that disagreements cluster systematically: by caste of holder, by holding size, by location within the village, by historical event (consolidation, settlement re-survey, partition), and by tenure type.

Chapter 6 is essentially a forensic exercise. Write it that way.

How to build the chapter

§6.1 — Methodology and ethics

Open with this. Three to four pages. The reader needs to know, before any findings appear, how the comparisons were done, what was compared against what, and what the limits are.

Cover the sample of parcels (how many at this granular level, why these, what the stratification logic was — you almost certainly want a purposive sample stratified by holder caste, holding size, tenure type, and location within the village). Cover the cross-checking protocol: for each parcel, what sources of evidence were assembled — Bhulekh RoR (digital), paper RoR (where extant), Sabik reference (where retrievable), Bhunaksha screenshot, ground measurement (with whatever tool: GPS, chain-tape, the *amin*'s assistance), registered deeds, mutation files, FRA pattas, oral testimony from the holder, and cross-testimony from neighbours.

Then describe the matching matrix: the comparative table that, for each parcel, lays out what each source says about ownership, extent, boundary, *kissam*, and mutation history. This is the analytical backbone of the chapter. Make the methodology visible.

Cover ethics: pseudonymisation; protocols for findings that could be politically explosive (disputed parcels, encroachments, livestock or forest land claims). And cover the limits of the method honestly: GPS may not be survey-grade; *amin*-chain measurement is approximate; Sabik records require help to read; the sample is not exhaustive. Honesty strengthens authority. A reader who knows what you could not do will trust what you did do.

§6.2 — The Sabik-Hal palimpsest at parcel scale

Begin substantive analysis with the deepest temporal layer. Every parcel in your village carries a record-history that extends back through the Hal settlement (1980s or 1990s in most of Odisha), the Sabik settlement (often the Maddox-era 1900s to 1920s in coastal Odisha, or even later in the Garhjats), pre-Maddox arrangements where retrievable, and possibly pre-colonial customary memory carried orally.

For twenty to twenty-five parcels, document what Sabik showed and what Hal showed. You will find discrepancies — names changed, extents adjusted, kissam reclassified, boundaries shifted. These discrepancies are not corrections in any straightforward sense; they are layered authoritative statements, each made at a different historical moment with different methods and different administrative purposes.

The political-economic analysis then asks: who gained and who lost in the Sabik-Hal transition? In Odisha specifically, where consolidation was incomplete and where the Hal settlement coincided with post-Estate-Abolition allocations to former tenants, the Sabik-Hal comparison reveals whose names were entered and whose were dropped, whose extents grew and whose shrank, whose kissam was upgraded and whose downgraded. This is the historical underbelly of digitisation: Bhulekh inherits the Hal record, which inherits the Sabik record, which inherits the Maddox cadastre, which inherits the colonial revenue settlement. The errors and inequities cascade downward; digitisation locks them in.

§6.3 — RoR-Bhunaksha disagreement: textual-spatial divergence

This is the most technically distinctive section, because most thesis writers cannot do it — and you can.

Bhulekh separates textual records (the RoR, listing owner, extent, kissam, encumbrances) from spatial records (Bhunaksha, the cadastral map). In a properly integrated system, the two should agree absolutely. In practice, they do not.

For each parcel in your sample, compare the RoR-stated extent against the Bhunaksha-calculated polygon area. Compare the RoR-listed neighbours against the Bhunaksha-shown neighbours. Build a table of disagreements.

The patterns are typically the following: disagreements cluster at the edges of holdings; where village boundaries meet government land; near recently mutated parcels; where consolidation was incomplete.

The political-economic analysis: when RoR and Bhunaksha disagree, which is treated as authoritative, for what purposes, and by whom? For PM-Kisan eligibility, the RoR is used. For physical demarcation in a dispute, Bhunaksha is referenced. For ULPIN assignment, both must agree — and where they do not, ULPIN assignment stalls. This textual-spatial divergence is itself productive of new disputes and new exclusions.

§6.4 — Digital record vs paper record vs ground reality

Three-way comparison. Walk the parcels with the household, measure with whatever tools you have available, compare against what Bhulekh shows and what the household's paper RoR shows.

Several categories of discrepancy will emerge. **Extent discrepancies:** the recorded extent does not match the measured extent. **Boundary discrepancies:** the recorded boundary lines diverge from the physical boundaries, because hedges, *aa/s*, bunds, or tree lines have moved with cultivation. **Location discrepancies:** in extreme cases the parcel cannot be located on the map

at the stated coordinates. **Inclusion discrepancies:** parts of the actually cultivated area are not in the record at all. **Exclusion discrepancies:** parts of the record do not exist on the ground because they have been encroached, lost to road-widening, or lost to erosion.

Then, the analytically most important move: across your sample, document which holders experience which discrepancies. Smaller holders, women holders, Adivasi holders, marginal-caste holders — versus dominant-caste larger holders. The argument the section makes is that *discrepancy is socially distributed*. This is the empirical heart of Chapter 6.

§6.5 — Mutation chains

This will be the most narratively rich section. For eight to twelve carefully chosen parcels, trace the full mutation chain across decades: who acquired the parcel from whom, when, on the basis of what document, with what disputes along the way. Each mutation is a moment of contact between household and bureaucracy. The chain reveals patterns.

Three kinds of finding are particularly important. **Mutations stuck:** pending sometimes for years. Document who is harmed by the delay (the heir, the woman to be co-recorded, the buyer in an unregistered transfer). **Mutations never recorded:** where actual cultivation has shifted but the record has not, producing a class of invisible transactions that the official record cannot see. **Mutations retrospectively recorded:** the most contentious category, where someone has produced a deed and had a mutation recorded that the original holder disputes. Bhulekh now shows the contested version as authoritative.

The political-economic framing: mutation is the moment of transfer of legibility, and therefore the moment of greatest contestation and greatest bureaucratic discretion. Connect this section back to §5.2's discussion of brokerage — brokers are most active at the moment of mutation.

§6.6 — Kissam, common land, customary tenure

Bhulekh records private agricultural parcels meticulously. It records government land less well. And it records common land — *gochar* (grazing), *baori* (water tank), *jangal* (forest), *padaar* (uplands) — in ways that are systematically vulnerable to misrecording, misclassification, and conversion to private use.

Where your villages contain FRA-eligible land, document how it appears in Bhulekh, or fails to. Sometimes *pattas* have been issued but no Bhunaksha polygon exists. Sometimes a polygon exists but the kissam shows it as forest. Sometimes both exist but conflict over what they say. This juridical incoherence — heritable rights over land that the cadastral system records as forest — is itself a major political-economic finding.

The conceptual frame here links back to Chapter 2 (Scott, Cohn, Tania Li): customary, common, and forest tenure systems are structurally illegible to a parcel-based digital system. This is not a failure of DILRMP. It is a constitutive feature of cadastral modernity.

§6.7 — The parcel-welfare nexus

This section closes the analytical loop with §3.3 and §5.5. The argument: parcel-level discrepancies translate directly into welfare exclusions.

PM-Kisan exclusions traced to parcel-level problems. For each excluded household identified in Chapter 5, return to the parcel-level record and trace the cause. The eKYC failed because two slightly different spellings of the same name produced two database records. The bank account did not link because the RoR extent did not match the registered deed extent. The land "is not in your name" because of a Sabik-Hal discrepancy that an officer noticed but the household did not. Document these chains in detail. They are the bridge between the parcel and the household.

KALIA vs PM-Kisan comparison. This directly supports the §3.3 substitution thesis at the empirical level. KALIA's broader inclusion criteria (including sharecroppers) reach households that PM-Kisan structurally cannot. Show this for specific households.

Credit access. Loans from formal sources require land as collateral. Parcel-level inaccuracies translate into denied or reduced credit, which translates into reliance on informal credit, which translates into specific patterns of agrarian distress.

§6.8 — Conclusion: from village to system

Two to three pages. Summarise the typology of discrepancies, the patterns of their distribution, and the welfare consequences. Then make the justifying analytical move: DILRMP has not failed in the parcel-level analysis; it has succeeded at digitising and authorising an inherited regime of inaccuracy. The political-economic significance is that the inaccuracy is now harder to challenge, because it carries digital authority. The contest over land records, once between people and patwaris, has become a contest between people and databases. This shift disadvantages those who have least access to the means of challenge — brokers, lawyers, Tahsildar appointments, digital interfaces.

Writing craft for Chapter 6

The language of forensics

Use words like "evidence," "trace," "establish," "corroborate," "contradict," "reconstruct," "ground-truth," "discrepancy," "match," "divergence." These give the chapter the texture of methodical investigation rather than ethnographic narrative. The voice should differ from Chapter 5.

Tables and figures, sparingly but powerfully

A clean table comparing RoR, Bhunaksha, and ground measurement for a single parcel does enormous analytical work. Three or four well-chosen tables and two or three figures across the entire chapter is enough. Do not overload.

Parcel identifiers

Adopt a pseudonymisation scheme that lets you refer back to the same parcel across the chapter — "Parcel V1-K12-P03" (village 1, khatian 12, plot 03), or similar. This allows the reader to follow specific parcels through the analysis.

Hold the line on political-economic interpretation

Every category of discrepancy must lead to a political-economic interpretation. Do not let the chapter become a technical inventory. Each section must end on the analytical point: why does this matter, who gains, who loses, how does this connect to the larger argument?

Show your work

Where you measured, say with what tool. Where you read a Sabik record, say with whose help. Where you have a screenshot, present it. The reader's confidence in the findings grows in proportion to the transparency of the method.

Voice authority

"In our village, twenty-two of sixty-seven surveyed parcels carried extent discrepancies exceeding ten per cent; the discrepancies were not random." Not "according to the literature, cadastral records in India often suffer from inaccuracies." The difference between those two sentences is the entire chapter.

Overclaiming and underclaiming

The greatest risk is overclaiming on the evidence of one village. The opposite risk — underclaiming, presenting findings as merely local — is also real. The right balance: be specific about what the evidence shows; be careful about generalisation; and be confident about identifying patterns within your sample.

The complete reading list

Cadastral, GIS, and parcel-level technical literature

- ★★★ **DoLR (Gol)**, *DILRMP: Approach/Methodology for Ground Truthing in Resurvey and Map Publishing*. **Primary**. The five-layered approach (HRSI/ORI base layer, grid making, ground truthing by surveyor using mobile applications and GNSS rovers, digitisation with attributes, parcel/village boundary map published after QAQC) is precisely what your fieldwork is checking. Cite directly.
- ★★★ **"Cadastral Resurvey and Integration of Geospatial Technique using HRSI: A Case Study in Indian District" (2022)**, *Applied Geomatics* (Springer). Compares chain-tape survey, computer-aided digitisation, and HRSI-based methods.
- ★★★ **"Constructing a Seamless Digital Cadastral Database using Colonial Cadastral Maps and VHR Imagery — An Indian Perspective" (2015)**, Taylor & Francis. **Essential**. Peer-reviewed technical grounding for the discrepancy findings.

- ★★ "GIS-based Land Information System using Cadastral Model: Bardhaman Case Study" (2016), *Modeling Earth Systems and Environment* (Springer)
- ★★ B. O. Binns and P. F. Dale (1995), *Cadastral Surveys and Records of Rights in Land*, FAO
- ★★ Peter Dale and John McLaughlin (2000), *Land Administration*, OUP

DILRMP technical implementation

- ★★★ DoLR Operational Manual, especially the sections on cadastral resurvey, mutation procedures, Bhunaksha integration, and ULPIN assignment. Primary; cite directly.
- ★★★ DoLR (2022), *Best Practices in DILRMP* booklet
- ★★★ DILRMP MIS Dashboard (dilrmp.gov.in) — Odisha-specific numbers (ULPIN status, cadastral digitisation, RoR-Bhunaksha integration)
- ★★★ NCAER (2020), *DILRMP Synthesis Report* — re-read for what they could *not* find using state-level statistics; your parcel evidence fills the gap.
- ★★ Anirudh Burman (2019, 2020), NIPFP papers

Land disputes and litigation

- ★★★ PRS, Daksh, Vidhi Centre for Legal Policy working papers on land disputes
- ★★★ CPR Land Rights Initiative — Wahi et al. litigation database
- ★★★ Land Conflict Watch (TISS-affiliated) — for empirical anchoring
- ★★ Anirudh Burman, NIPFP integration papers
- ★★ State Revenue Court and Revenue Officer manuals for Odisha

Odisha-specific technical material

- ★★★ Bhulekh Odisha portal — systematically explored
- ★★★ Bhunaksha Odisha portal — systematically explored
- ★★★ e-Pauti / Odisha Land Revenue Portal
- ★★★ Revenue Court Case Management System (RCCMS) — Odisha — for parcel-level dispute data. Enormously valuable for §6.5.
- ★★★ Smart RoRs (February 2026 onwards) — the most recent digital layer
- ★★ Cambridge "Computerisation of Land Records Programme in Odisha"
- ★★ Maddox Settlement Reports — re-engage at the parcel level

Terminology and procedural literature

- ★★★ AssetYogi, *Land Records Terminology in India* — pan-Indian glossary (patwari, kanungo, girdawar, intkal, hadbast, jamabandi, haqdar, hibba, pattanama)
- ★★ Punjab Land Records Manual, Bengal Land Records Manual, Odisha Mutation Manual, Odisha Revenue Code
- ★★ Indian Stamp Act 1899; Registration Act 1908; Transfer of Property Act 1882

Bureaucracy-ethnography canon

- ★★★ Akhil Gupta (2012), *Red Tape* — re-engage for §6.5
- ★★★ Veena Das (2004), "Signature of the State" — the paradox of illegibility documented at scale
- ★★ Matthew Hull (2012), *Government of Paper: The Materiality of Bureaucracy in Urban Pakistan*, University of California Press. **Highly relevant — methodological model for §6.5.**
- ★★ Annelise Riles (2006), *Documents: Artifacts of Modern Knowledge*, University of Michigan Press

Financialisation and titling theoretical literature

- ★★★ Brenna Bhandar (2018), *Colonial Lives of Property*, Duke UP. **Re-read for parcel-scale insights.**
- ★★★ Tania Murray Li (2014), *Land's End* — methodologically the closest precedent
- ★★ Sara Berry (2009), "Property, Authority and Citizenship"
- ★★ Christian Lund and Catherine Boone (2013), "Land Politics in Africa"
- ★★ Alain Pottage (1995), "The Originality of Registration"

Methodology of forensic and granular evidence

- ★★ Carlo Ginzburg (1989/1980), "Clues: Roots of an Evidential Paradigm" — foundational on forensic methodology
- ★★ Lawrence Stone (1979), "The Revival of Narrative"
- ★★ Anne Stoler (2009), *Along the Archival Grain*, Princeton UP
- ★★ Eyal Weizman et al., Forensic Architecture methodology

Inheritance and intergenerational transfer

- ★★ Bina Agarwal (1994, 2003)
- ★★ Hindu Succession Act 1956 and 2005 Amendment — primary
- ★★ Indian Succession Act 1925

Forest, FRA, and Adivasi tenure at parcel scale

- ★★★ Forest Rights Act 2006 — primary, read at the patta-issuance and parcel-recognition level
- ★★ Vasundhara field reports — **parcel-level documentation of FRA failures is methodologically the closest precedent for Schedule V villages.**
- ★★ Madhu Sarin and Oliver Springate-Baginski — multiple papers
- ★★ CFR-LA reports
- ★★ Centre for Equity Studies (2017), *Promise and Performance: Ten Years of the Forest Rights Act*

A six-week writing sequence

- **Week 1:** Build the parcel-database. For each parcel in your sample (forty to eighty total), construct a clean comparative table: Bhulekh extent, Bhunaksha extent, paper RoR extent, measured extent, listed owner, actual cultivator, kissam, neighbours, mutation status, FRA status, welfare scheme outcomes. **This database is the analytical infrastructure of the chapter.**
- **Week 2:** Identify patterns from the database. Draft §6.1 (methodology) and §6.2 (Sabik-Hal).
- **Week 3:** Draft §6.3 (RoR-Bhunaksha) and §6.4 (digital-paper-ground). Use specific parcels throughout.
- **Week 4:** Draft §6.5 (mutation chains). The narrative high point of the chapter. Take time on it.
- **Week 5:** Draft §6.6 (kissam, commons, customary) and §6.7 (welfare consequences). Then §6.8 (conclusion) and §6.0 (chapter introduction).
- **Week 6:** Revise. Each section's opening should land an analytical sentence; each closing should land a political-economic point. Make sure pseudonymisation is consistent throughout. Have a colleague read for clarity.

The deepest advice on Chapter 6

Chapter 6 is the chapter where your committee will decide either "this is original work that contributes to the field" or "this is competent but not distinctive." There is no middle position.

If you write Chapter 6 as a careful, granular, forensically disciplined demonstration that digital land records do not match the land they purport to record — and that the patterns of mismatch are politically structured — you have produced original empirical scholarship. There is no peer-reviewed study at this level of granularity for Indian land records. Your thesis will become a reference work.

If you write it as a series of impressionistic observations about discrepancies, without the systematic comparative architecture, the parcel-level discipline, and the political-economic interpretation, the chapter becomes another extended case study and the originality drops away.

The difference is in the discipline. Chapter 6 must be the most disciplined chapter in the thesis. Every claim must be traceable to specific parcels. Every pattern must be documented across multiple cases. Every interpretation must be defended against the obvious objections (cherry-picking, small sample, measurement error). This is not a constraint on the chapter; it is what makes the chapter persuasive.

This chapter is yours in a way that no chapter before it could be. Chapters 2 and 3 synthesised existing literature. Chapter 4 set up the Odisha context. Chapter 5 documented village-level experience. Chapter 6 is where you have measured what no one else has measured and tracked what no one else has tracked. The evidence is uniquely yours; the interpretation must be too.

Suggested chapter title

"Parcel-Level Findings" is serviceable but bland. Consider something more analytically distinctive, such as:

- **"The Parcel Beneath the Portal: Discrepancy, Authority, and the Digital Cadastre"**
- **"What Bhulekh Cannot See: A Forensic Reading of Land Records at Parcel Scale"**

Either signals to the reader, before the chapter opens, that something distinctive is being attempted.

Chapter 7 — Conclusion

What the conclusion actually is

Most doctoral conclusions fail in the same way: they summarise. They walk the reader through what each preceding chapter argued, restate the main findings, end with paragraphs on directions for future research. This is what your committee has been trained to expect — which means it is also what no committee remembers ten minutes after closing the document.

A conclusion that succeeds does something different. It performs four moves, in this order.

First, it states what the thesis has *established* — not what it argued, but what is now known that was not known before. The verb shifts from "this thesis argues" to "this thesis establishes." The register is one of completed work, not ongoing inquiry.

Second, it makes the theoretical contribution visible: where, in Development Studies, in the political economy of land in India, in institutional economics, in village studies, does your thesis now sit? What can scholars working in these fields not ignore that they could have ignored before?

Third, it makes the practical and political contribution visible. What does this thesis mean for how land records modernisation is, could be, or should be done?

Fourth, it situates the thesis in the broader political moment. Indian land records modernisation is part of a large transformation in how the post-1991 state knows, governs, and distributes resources. The conclusion earns the right to name that transformation and to locate the thesis within it.

The conclusion is your last and best opportunity to be remembered. Treat it as such.

The six-section architecture

§7.1 — What this thesis has established

Three or four pages. Open with a clear declarative restatement of what the thesis has shown — not chapter by chapter, but organised by what is now known. The temptation to summarise chapter-by-chapter is strong; resist it.

Begin with the central finding: *DILRMP is not the technocratic administrative reform it presents itself as, but the administrative apparatus through which the post-1991 Indian state simultaneously commodifies land, targets welfare through digital legibility, and constructs a market-compatible juridical subject — and the contradictions between these projects produce the stratified outcomes that the village and parcel-level evidence documents.*

Then organise into specific established findings, not by chapter but by domain of knowledge:

- **On the history of Indian land records:** the thesis has established that Indian land records are a palimpsest of pre-colonial fiscal-tributary infrastructure, colonial-capitalist juridical instruments, post-independence redistributive instruments, and neoliberal digital instruments

— and that DILRMP attempts to flatten this palimpsest without acknowledging its constituent layers.

- **On the political economy of land records modernisation:** DILRMP is unintelligible outside the post-1991 neoliberal turn, the World Bank's land policy doctrine, the NITI Aayog Model Bill on conclusive titling, and the techno-patrimonial welfare regime that has emerged since 2014.
- **On the substitution argument:** DBT-based welfare schemes (PM-Kisan, KALIA, Subhadra) have substituted for structural reform of agrarian distress, with land records serving as the infrastructure that makes this substitution operationally possible.
- **On the Odisha-specific palimpsest:** Odisha's land governance is shaped by four sedimented institutional inheritances overlain by post-independence reforms and now by Bhulekh, producing specific patterns of legibility and exclusion that vary systematically across coastal, inland, plains, hills, general, and Scheduled Areas.
- **On the village-level evidence:** DILRMP produces stratified outcomes — beneficial for some households, irrelevant for others, harmful for still others — patterned by caste, class, gender, tenure status, location, and proximity to local bureaucracy. These are not implementation failures; they are the predictable distributive effects of a technocratic reform that abstracts from the social structures it claims to transcend.
- **On the parcel-level evidence:** the digital records system carries systematic material discrepancies that are not random errors but socially structured patterns, with direct consequences for welfare access and credit.

This is the established record. Present it as such. Do not hedge.

§7.2 — The compressed argument

The most important section in the chapter. Two to three pages. Make the single integrated argument visible in its most powerful and condensed form. Strip away qualifications. Write as if you had ten minutes to convince a hostile but intelligent reader that the thesis is correct.

A model compressed argument might read:

Indian land records modernisation cannot be understood as a technocratic administrative project. It is the contemporary phase of a centuries-long political-economic process through which the Indian state — colonial and post-colonial — has produced legibility over land in ways that systematically structure who can claim, hold, transact, mortgage, and benefit from land. DILRMP, conclusive titling, ULPIN, Bhu-Aadhaar, AgriStack — these are not technical instruments; they are the contemporary form of a project that runs from the Mughal zabt-dahsala through Cornwallis's Permanent Settlement through post-independence land reform to today. What makes the contemporary phase distinctive is that it operates simultaneously as commodification (preparing land for capital), legibility (targeting welfare to populations), and juridification (constructing market-compatible subjects); that it does this through digital infrastructures that abstract from the social structures determining who can convert legibility into security; and that it substitutes for structural reform of agrarian distress through cash transfers whose distribution depends on the very land records it is producing. The thesis has shown all of this — historically in Chapter 2, politically in Chapter 3, contextually in Chapter 4, and empirically in Chapters 5 and 6.

Your version of that paragraph is what your committee will quote back to you. Write it well.

§7.3 — Theoretical contributions

Three to four pages. For each literature, state precisely what the thesis adds.

To Development Studies on technocracy and the anti-politics machine. Ferguson and Li theorise how development systematically depoliticises inherently political questions. The thesis adds parcel-level forensic evidence and demonstrates that digitisation does not eliminate political contestation but redistributes it — from human bureaucracy to database authority. The contest over land records has shifted from between people and patwaris to between people and portals.

To the political economy of land in India. Levien, Lerche, Pratyush, and Benjamin built the theoretical apparatus. The thesis adds: the electoral-political-economy frame connecting DBT-substitution to land records infrastructure (an original link the existing literature has not made explicitly); the parcel-level empirical method; and the Odisha-specific palimpsest analysis.

To the new institutional economics literature on property rights. De Soto, Deininger, Banerjee and Iyer, Acemoglu and Robinson made the case for secure rights as preconditions for development. The thesis engages on its own terms, showing that even where formal institutions are in place, material conditions — of caste, class, gender, bureaucratic access, customary tenure, and parcel-level accuracy — determine who can convert title into security. This is not a rejection of NIE but a refinement that NIE itself cannot produce, because it operates at a scale too aggregated to see the parcel.

To the village-studies tradition. Srinivas, Bêteille, Harriss, Jodhka, Gupta, and Krishnamurthy built the methodological canon. The thesis adds a new analytical site (the digital-cadastral interface) and a new methodological move (parcel-level forensic comparison alongside household ethnography). Village studies now has a method for studying the land records system from the inside.

To the literature on electoral political economy of cash transfers. Aiyar, Sircar, Tillin, Subramanian, and Chhibber and Verma have framed the new welfarism debate. The thesis adds the missing infrastructural link: the labharthi varg is constructed through specific land records, biometric, and digital infrastructures, and the quality and accuracy of those infrastructures determines who is included and excluded.

§7.4 — Methodological reflections

Two to three pages. Honest methodological reflection strengthens, rather than weakens, the thesis. Three subsections.

What this method allowed the thesis to see. The multi-scale approach — historical, political-economic, government-documentary, village-ethnographic, parcel-forensic — is itself a methodological contribution. No single method would have produced the argument. The ability to move from the Maddox Settlement Reports to the DILRMP MIS Dashboard to a specific mutation file to a measured field boundary is the method's signature.

What this method could not see. Specific villages and one state. Did not study the urban SVAMITVA implementation, the view from inside state revenue departments, large landowner behaviour, or the dynamics in states with more complete land reform histories (Kerala, West Bengal). Be honest here; it disarms objections.

What would be done differently. A larger comparative sample across two or three states; more time observing file movement inside Tahsildar and Sub-Collector offices; a longitudinal return survey after five years.

§7.5 — Implications for policy and practice

Three to four pages. Not recommendations in the technocratic mode — implications that follow from the evidence, with political-economic awareness.

On DILRMP and conclusive titling. The parcel-level evidence shows that conclusive titling cannot deliver on its promises until Sabik-Hal reconciliation, RoR-Bhunaksha integration, ground-truthing in Scheduled Areas, and recognition of customary tenure are all completed. The NITI Aayog Model Bill 2020 presumes prerequisites that the evidence shows are not in place.

On welfare scheme design. The substitution argument suggests that land-records-dependent schemes (PM-Kisan) systematically exclude exactly those most needing support. KALIA versus PM-Kisan shows what inclusive design looks like: it acknowledges that land records exclude, and designs around the exclusion.

On Scheduled Areas and FRA. The cadastral logic of DILRMP is fundamentally incompatible with customary, collective, and FRA tenure. Separate institutional pathways are needed for the more than a third of Odisha's land area that falls under these categories.

On the politics of digital welfare delivery. The labharthi-varg analysis and the substitution thesis together suggest that the political dynamic is unlikely to be reversed by technical implementation improvements alone. The debate must shift from "better implementation" to "better design" and beyond that to structural questions about employment, agrarian distress, and the adequacy of cash as a substitute for reform.

On methodology for evaluation. The NCAER, NIPFP, and IGIDR state-level evaluations are the best existing assessments of DILRMP. The parcel-level evidence shows they cannot capture the most consequential dimensions. Future evaluation should integrate forensic parcel-level methods alongside statistical aggregation.

§7.6 — Directions for further research

Two pages. Treat this as the opening of a research programme, not the closing of a study.

- Comparative parcel-level analysis across states (Karnataka, Andhra Pradesh, Madhya Pradesh, Bihar)
- Longitudinal parcel-tracking — return to the same parcels in five years
- Urban land records and SVAMITVA/NAKSHA
- The view from inside the revenue bureaucracy — ethnographic work with Tahsildars, Revenue Inspectors, and state-level officials

- Gender and inheritance at parcel scale, following the 2005 Hindu Succession Act amendment
- The AgriStack moment — federated farmer database — as the next chapter of this story

End with a sentence indicating that you intend to pursue some of this. It positions you not as someone who has finished a project but as a researcher with a programme.

§7.7 — A final reflection

One to two pages. Briefly, with some understatement, make the political and intellectual point that the entire thesis has been building toward.

The post-1991 Indian state has built, and continues to build, vast digital infrastructures of legibility: Aadhaar, PAN, GST, Bhulekh, ULPIN, AgriStack, the Digital Public Infrastructure stack. Presented as technologies of inclusion, efficiency, and welfare, they are also — as the thesis has shown — technologies of sorting. They determine who is seen and who is not, whose rights are recorded and whose are not, who receives transfers and who is excluded, whose claim to land carries digital authority and whose does not.

The advocates of digital governance are sincere; many believe genuinely in the welfare effects. But sincerity is not evidence. The evidence is what the thesis has produced — at the level of specific parcels, specific households, specific mutation files, specific discrepancies between what Bhulekh says and what the land says.

Close with something that opens outward rather than closes inward. The questions pursued — about how the state knows land, how it transforms knowing into governance, how governance distributes opportunity and exclusion — are not Indian questions only. They are the questions of the digital age. The Indian land records modernisation project is one of the largest experiments in digital governance undertaken in any democratic society. What it produces will matter not only for the people on whose land the parcels are drawn, but for how digital governance is understood and evaluated globally. The thesis is an early empirical chapter in that larger story.

Writing craft for the conclusion

Voice

This is the most authoritative voice in the thesis. "I have shown," "the thesis has established," "the evidence demonstrates" — these constructions are now appropriate. Earlier chapters could be cautious; this one cannot. The reader has spent six chapters following you; they want to know what you think, not what the literature says.

Citation density

Citations should be sparse. The conclusion is not a place to introduce new literature except where strictly necessary. The reader does not need sources in this chapter — they need the argument.

Length

Eight thousand to ten thousand words. Shorter reads like hedging; longer reads like not knowing where to stop. The proportions above are a guide: §7.1 and §7.3 longest; §7.4, §7.5, §7.6, §7.7 shorter; §7.2 shortest at two pages but carrying the heaviest analytical load.

The very last sentence

Spend disproportionate time on it. The last sentence is what your committee will read just before deciding what they think of you. It should not summarise; it should land.

The kind of sentence: "The land beneath the portal is the same land it has always been; what has changed is who can see it, on whose authority, and to whose benefit." Or: "The story this thesis has told is not one of bureaucratic failure or technological success; it is a story of how the digital age inherits the older politics of property, and digitises them."

Relationship to Chapter 1

After writing the conclusion, return to Chapter 1 and revise it. The best introductions are written last, from the conclusion outward. Make sure every question raised in Chapter 1 is answered here.

References in the conclusion

Draw overwhelmingly on references already cited. Two or three new references are permissible — for the broader political-moment framing in §7.7 (Virginia Eubanks's *Automating Inequality*, Wendy Brown's *In the Ruins of Neoliberalism*, recent essays by Pratap Bhanu Mehta or Suhas Palshikar) — but new material should be minimal. The conclusion's authority comes from saying what the thesis established, not from introducing what it did not engage with.

A three-week writing sequence

- **Week 1:** Re-read the entire thesis from beginning to end in one or two sustained sittings. Take notes on what each chapter established, what each almost said, and which threads run across all six chapters. Identify the single integrated argument. Identify the four or five most important findings. Begin drafting §7.2 — the compressed argument — in longhand if that helps. It will take multiple attempts.
- **Week 2:** Draft §7.1 (what is established) and §7.3 (theoretical contributions). These are the two longest and most demanding sections.
- **Week 3:** Draft §7.4, §7.5, §7.6, and §7.7. Then the chapter introduction (§7.0, one to two pages). Revise the entire chapter as one piece. Revise the thesis abstract to match the conclusion's confident register.

The deepest advice on the conclusion

When you sit down to write the conclusion, you will be tired. The thesis will have taken three years, perhaps five. You will be ready to be done.

The temptation will be to write a competent conclusion that closes the document — summary, contribution, limitations, further research, end. Most doctoral conclusions are written this way. Most are forgotten by the committee within minutes of the viva ending.

The chapter you have the *opportunity* to write is one your committee will quote back to you for the next ten years. It is the chapter where, having earned the right through sixty or eighty thousand words of careful work, you write with full authority about what you have done, what it means, and why it matters.

Almost no one writes this chapter, because almost no one believes, at the end of a doctoral thesis, that they have the right to. You do. You have done the work. You have walked the parcels. You have read the patta in the cupboard. You have measured the discrepancy between what Bhulekh says and what the land says. You have spoken to the Tahsildar and the RI and the amin and the widow whose husband's mutation has been pending for two years and the Adivasi household whose forest land is not on the map. You have read the Maddox Settlement Reports and the NITI Aayog Model Bill and the 15th Finance Commission and the Niyamgiri judgement and the Drèze-Khera Aadhaar studies and the Aiyar-Sircar techno-patrimonialism papers. You have built three theoretical traditions in conversation across four historical regimes. You have mapped Odisha's four-fold tenorial palimpsest. You have constructed the parcel-level forensic method that no one else has brought to Indian land records.

The work is done. The conclusion is where you write as someone who has done it. That is the only advice that matters.

— End of Document —

Compiled from an extended research consultation on writing a doctoral thesis on the political economy of land records modernisation in India, with village and parcel-level fieldwork in Odisha.